

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Yoga - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Yoga

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 mind-field (citta)
- 2 mental modifications (citta-vṛttis)
- 3 afflictions (kleśas)
- 4 meditative absorption (samādhi)
- 5 isolation (kaivalya)
- 6 eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga)

Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Yoga - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

Evidence discipline: Complete legacy teaching and workbook material is preserved, reordered Basic-first/Advanced-last, and checked against the canonical owner and verified 2018-2025 PYQ ledger.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

Yoga

English-first concept spine • Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows in parentheses

- 1 mind-field (citta)
- 2 mental modifications (citta-vṛttis)
- 3 afflictions (kleśas)
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Read the complete Markdown/PDF for arguments, objections, PYQs and model answers.

Yoga English-first concept spine

Concept spine: English concepts lead; Sanskrit/Pali IAST follows immediately.

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Syllabus (verbatim): Yoga; Mind-field (citta); Mental modification (citta-vṛtti); Afflictions (kleśas); Meditative absorption (samādhi); Isolation (kaivalya). **Evidence key:** FACT: canonical doctrine · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis · CAUTION: contested **Placement:** Yoga is the practical-soteriological counterpart of Sāṃkhya in Paper I Indian philosophy. UPSC repeatedly asks mind-field (citta), restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha), kleśa-removal, meditative absorption (samādhi), isolation (kaivalya) and the distinct place of Lord (Īśvara) in **theistic Samkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya)**.

How to use this layered session

Every logical subtopic follows the Philosophy five-layer sequence:

Layer	Purpose
1. SIMPLE START	Plain-language visual gateway
2. CORE UPSC	Complete retained doctrine, terminology, arguments and examples
3. ADVANCED	Objections, replies, comparisons and qualified evaluation
4. EXAM APPLICATION	Verified PYQ routing and marks-wise answer structure
5. RAPID REVISION	Traps, recall spines and mastery preparation

Source audit: the canonical Yoga knowledge file and complete 2018-2025 Indian Philosophy PYQ bank were checked. The source session's direct OCR anchors to Chatterjee-Datta and C. D. Sharma are retained. The official

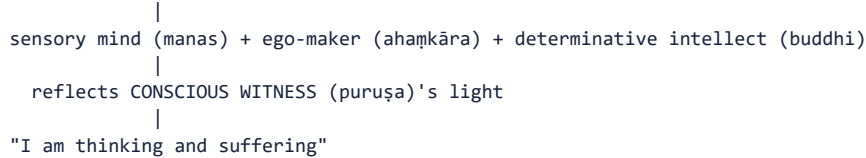
2026 International Day of Yoga theme and Ministry of Ayush context were rechecked and are used only as a contemporary public-health anchor, not as evidence for Patanjala metaphysics. Qdrant was not required.

Preservation note: every substantive section of the earlier complete session is retained. The new material adds simple visual gateways and explicit learning layers without replacing or compressing the original depth.

SESSION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

Plain-language visual - the mind is the instrument, not the self

OBJECTS -> SENSES -> MIND-FIELD (citta)



Yoga disciplines mind-field (citta) so witness and instrument are no longer confused.

In simple words: Yoga accepts Samkhya's Purusa-Prakriti dualism but develops a detailed practical psychology. Mind-field (citta) is the subtle material mind-complex; Conscious witness (puruṣa) is the conscious witness.

Mind-field (citta) condition	Easy meaning
Restless mind (kṣipta)	Restless
Dull mind (mūḍha)	Dull
Distracted mind (vikṣipta)	Sometimes focused
One-pointed mind (ekāgra)	One-pointed
Fully restrained mind (niruddha)	Fully restrained

Memory line: Samkhya gives the map; Yoga trains the mind that misreads the map.

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

YOGA = sāṃkhya-pravacana + Lord (Īśvara) + disciplined soteriology

Metaphysical base: 25 principles (tattvas) shared with Sāṃkhya

Practical field: mind-field (citta) (mind-complex) becomes coloured by objects and reflects conscious witness (puruṣa)

Problem: mental modifications (citta-vṛttis) + afflictions (kleśas) -> action and moral consequence (karma) -> vipāka -> āśaya -> punarjanma

Method: sustained practice (abhyāsa) + dispassion (vairāgya); preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga); eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga); Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna)

Culmination: meditative absorption (samādhi) -> discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) -> para-vairāgya -> cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi)

End: isolation (kaivalya) = isolation/aloneness of conscious witness (puruṣa) from primordial material nature (prakṛti)

ANALYSIS: Exam key: Yoga is not merely posture-discipline. It is a full theory of mind, bondage, meditative cognition and liberation built on Sāṃkhya ontology but modified by the admission of **Lord (Īśvara)** as **puruṣa-viśeṣa**.

INTRODUCTION - YOGA AS THEISTIC SAMKHYA (seśvara-sāṃkhya)

- **FACT:** Classical Yoga is often described as **sāṃkhya-pravacana** or **theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya)**: it shares the metaphysical structure of Sāṃkhya but adds a practical path and a theistic element.

- FACT: It accepts the basic dualism of **conscious witness (puruṣa)** and **primordial material nature (prakṛti)**, and the standard **25 principles (tattvas)** of Sāṃkhya.
- FACT: What Yoga adds is a carefully graded **soteriology**: control of mind-field (citta), attenuation of afflictions (kleśas), meditative absorption, and final isolation (kaivalya).
- FACT: It also admits **Lord (Īśvara)**, a **special conscious witness (puruṣa)** untouched by affliction and karmic residue, thereby distinguishing itself from nirīśvara Sāṃkhya.
- ANALYSIS: Thus the school may be summed up as: **Sāṃkhya gives the metaphysical map; Yoga gives the psychology and method of release.**
- ANALYSIS: In UPSC answers, this introductory framing immediately prevents two confusions: Yoga is neither merely physical culture nor an Advaitic path of union with Brahman.

1. MIND-FIELD (citta)

1.1 Statement

- FACT: **Mind-field (citta)** (citta) is the internal organ or mind-complex through which cognition, affect, volition and meditative discipline become possible.
- FACT: In Yoga, mind-field (citta) is not merely **sensory mind (manas)** in isolation; it functions as the unified internal apparatus comprising **determinative intellect (buddhi)**, **ego-maker (ahaṃkāra)** and **sensory mind (manas)**.
- FACT: Its material basis is from primordial material nature (prakṛti) and, more specifically, from the **sāttvika** aspect of **ego-maker (ahaṃkāra)** in the Sāṃkhyan evolutionary scheme.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore mind-field (citta) is best understood as **the psychical instrument of experience**, not as the true self.

1.2 Constitution of mind-field (citta)

Component within the functioning unity of mind-field (citta)	Primary role	Why Yoga includes it under mind-field (citta)
Determinative intellect (buddhi)	determinative intellect, ascertainment	decisive cognition, discrimination, resolve occur here
Ego-maker (ahaṃkāra)	ego-principle, appropriation as "I"	ownership of states, doership and identification arise here
Sensory mind (manas)	sensory co-ordination, doubt, oscillation	receives and arranges sense-data, moves between options

- FACT: Though Sāṃkhya analytically distinguishes these, Yoga often treats them as one operative continuum called **mind-field (citta)**.
- ANALYSIS: This broad usage is philosophically useful because bondage and liberation both concern the **whole mental field**, not one isolated faculty.

1.3 Mind-field (citta) as reflective, not self-luminous in its own right

- FACT: Mind-field (citta) is a product of primordial material nature (prakṛti) and therefore **insentient** in itself.
- FACT: Yet because of its subtle, sāttvika transparency, it can **reflect** consciousness.
- FACT: The standard analogy is that of a **clear crystal placed near a flower**: the crystal appears coloured by the flower though it is itself colourless.
- FACT: Similarly, mind-field (citta) takes on the form and colour of objects placed before it, while the consciousness of **conscious witness (puruṣa)** is reflected in it.
- ANALYSIS: The empirical self arises when the reflected consciousness in mind-field (citta) is mistaken for the intrinsic nature of mind-field (citta) itself.
- ANALYSIS: Hence Yoga's theory of mind is neither crude materialism nor idealism: mind-field (citta) is material-subtle, but consciousness belongs originally to conscious witness (puruṣa).

1.4 Misidentification of self with mind-field (citta)

- FACT: So long as mind-field (citta) is modified by objects, memories, desires, fears and conceptual constructions, the self appears entangled in them.
- FACT: The reflective relation causes bondage when **discriminative knowledge** is absent.
- FACT: A standard exam-worthy formulation is: **so long as there are changes and modifications in mind-field (citta), the self is reflected therein and, lacking discriminative discernment, identifies itself with those modifications.**
- ANALYSIS: This is the psychological core of bondage in Yoga: the seer is confused with the seen because reflection masquerades as identity.

1.4A Reflection (pratibimba/chāyā) presuppositions

Statement. FACT: Yoga's reflection theory says that **mind-field (citta)** appears conscious because it stands near **conscious witness (puruṣa)**, while conscious witness (puruṣa) appears bound because its light is reflected in mind-field (citta); this is a **pratibimba** (pratibimba; reflection) or **chāyā** (chaya; shadow-image) model, not a literal alteration of conscious witness (puruṣa).

Argument.

1. FACT: **Conscious witness (puruṣa)** is **apariṇāmin** (aparinamin; unchanging) and therefore cannot literally act, suffer, acquire qualities or undergo modification.
2. FACT: **Mind-field (citta)** is a product of **primordial material nature (prakṛti)** and is therefore **jaḍa** (jada; insentient), yet its sattva-predominance makes it transparent, subtle and capable of mirroring.
3. FACT: Since an inactive consciousness cannot enter causal contact like one physical object striking another, knowledge requires a reflection/proximity model rather than a crude causal-contact model.
4. FACT: Bondage is therefore the confusion of **ego-identification (asmitā)** and **sva-svāmi-śakti** (sva-svami-shakti; the power of the owned and the owner): mind-field (citta)'s borrowed consciousness is misread as selfhood, and conscious witness (puruṣa)'s witnesshood is misread as agency.
5. ANALYSIS: The soteriological task is not to change conscious witness (puruṣa) but to end the cognitive misattribution by purifying and restraining mind-field (citta).

Presupposition. FACT: The model presupposes the Sāṃkhya-Yoga dualism of two irreducible orders: conscious but inactive conscious witness (puruṣa), and active but insentient primordial material nature (prakṛti)/mind-field (citta).

Example. FACT: The crystal (**sphaṭika**) near a red flower seems red without itself becoming the flower; ANALYSIS: similarly, a magnet and iron image helps exam writing: mere presence (**sannidhi**) can explain movement on the iron/mind-field (citta) side without action on the magnet/conscious witness (puruṣa) side.

Objection. ANALYSIS: A reflection normally requires some real relation between mirror and original. If conscious witness (puruṣa) and primordial material nature (prakṛti) are ontologically disjoint, how can inactive conscious witness (puruṣa) be "reflected" in mind-field (citta) at all?

Reply. FACT: Yoga replies through **sannidhi-mātra** (sannidhi-matra; mere proximity): the transformation is entirely on the mind-field (citta) side; conscious witness (puruṣa) neither acts nor changes. ANALYSIS: Yet the objection retains residual force, because Advaita and Nyāya can press the classic problem of how two radically different principles can explain one experience.

1.5 Why mind-field (citta) matters for soteriology

- FACT: Since bondage occurs through mind-field (citta), liberation must also be worked out through mind-field (citta).
- FACT: One does not destroy conscious witness (puruṣa)'s bondage by changing conscious witness (puruṣa) itself, because conscious witness (puruṣa) is eternally pure.
- FACT: Rather, one disciplines mind-field (citta) so completely that the false identification ceases.
- ANALYSIS: Yoga is therefore fundamentally a **therapy of attention, habit, impression and misidentification.**

1.6 Citta-bhūmis - the five levels or conditions of mind-field (citta)

- FACT: Yoga tradition classifies mind-field (citta) into **five bhūmis** or operative levels.

- FACT: These levels indicate the dominance of the qualities (guṇas) and the fitness of the mind for yoga.

Citta-bhūmi	Dominant guṇa-pattern	Basic character	Exam use
Restless mind (kṣipta) (kṣipta)	rajas dominant	restless, scattered, thrown outward	ordinary agitated mind
Dull mind (mūḍha) (mudha)	tamas dominant	dull, torpid, stupefied	lethargic, clouded mind
Distracted mind (vikṣipta) (vikṣipta)	mixed, with occasional sattva	intermittently focused but unstable	capable in bursts, still worldly
One-pointed mind (ekāgra) (ekagra)	sattva dominant	one-pointed, concentrated	fit for true yogic practice
Fully restrained mind (niruddha) (niruddha)	vṛttis restrained	all modifications arrested	culmination of yogic discipline

1.7 Explanation of the five bhūmis

(a) Restless mind (kṣipta)

- FACT: The mind runs from object to object under rajasic impulsion.
- FACT: There is activity, but not integration.
- ANALYSIS: Desire, worry, ambition and sensory dispersion dominate.

(b) Dull mind (mūḍha)

- FACT: The mind is overpowered by tamas.
- FACT: Torpor, delusion, inertia and confusion prevail.
- ANALYSIS: This state is not calmness but obscurity.

(c) Distracted mind (vikṣipta)

- FACT: The mind can attend, infer, analyse and even sustain brief concentration, but cannot remain inwardly collected.
- FACT: Sattva flashes forth occasionally, yet rajas and tamas are not overcome.
- ANALYSIS: This is the condition of many intelligent worldly persons: capable of focus, but not yet spiritually integrated.

(d) One-pointed mind (ekāgra)

- FACT: The mind becomes one-pointed on a chosen support.
- FACT: Sattva predominates sufficiently for meditative absorption to deepen.
- FACT: This is one of the two genuinely yoga-fit states.

(e) Fully restrained mind (niruddha)

- FACT: The modifications are fully restrained.
- FACT: This is not unconscious blankness but the consummation of disciplined inwardness.
- FACT: It is the citta-state correlated with the highest meditative absorption (samādhi) and the approach to isolation (kaivalya).

1.8 Which citta-bhūmis are fit for yoga?

- FACT: Only **one-pointed mind (ekāgra)** and **fully restrained mind (niruddha)** are fully fit for authentic yoga.
- FACT: **Restless mind (kṣipta)**, **dull mind (mūḍha)** and **distracted mind (vikṣipta)** remain pre-yogic or only partially prepared stages.
- ANALYSIS: The transition from distracted mind (vikṣipta) to one-pointed mind (ekāgra) is decisive: the mind moves from occasional concentration to sustained one-pointedness.

1.9 PYQ application: scientist, devotee, self-realized yogi

- FACT: UPSC in 2019 used the citta-bhūmi classification in applied form.
- FACT: A **scientist** intensely focused on an empirical problem yet still directed outward and attached to worldly ends is best classified as **distracted mind (vikṣipta)**.

- FACT: A **God-realized devotee** whose mind is one-pointedly centred upon Lord (Īśvara) is **one-pointed mind (ekāgra)**.
- FACT: A **self-realized yogi** in whom all modifications are fully stilled is **fully restrained mind (niruddha)**.
- ANALYSIS: The subtlety is important: high intellectual focus does not itself amount to yogic restraint.

1.10 Mind-field (citta) in inter-school perspective

School	What is the internal organ?	Key contrast with Yoga
Sāṃkhya	determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṃkāra), sensory mind (manas) analytically distinct	Yoga gathers them functionally as mind-field (citta)
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	sensory mind (manas) as atomic internal sense	Yoga's mind-field (citta) is far broader than atomic sensory mind (manas)
Vedānta	antaḥkaraṇa under ignorance (avidyā), with Brahman framework	Yoga retains plural conscious witness (puruṣas) and no Brahman-doctrine

1.11 Mini-conclusion on mind-field (citta)

- ANALYSIS: For UPSC, define mind-field (citta) as the **sāttvika psychical instrument composed of buddhi-ahaṃkāra-manas, reflecting conscious witness (puruṣa) and becoming modified by objects**.
- ANALYSIS: Then show why Yoga insists on discipline: without citta-niyama, conscious witness (puruṣa) continues to identify with borrowed mental states.

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Yoga as Theistic Sāṃkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

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0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

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INTRODUCTION - YOGA AS THEISTIC SĀMKNHYA (śeśvara-sāṃkhya)

->

1. MIND-FIELD (citta)

->

UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind

Plain-language visual - why even true thoughts are waves

MIND-FIELD (citta) takes the form of:

true knowledge | error | word-construction | sleep | memory

|
CONSCIOUS WITNESS (puruṣa) identifies
|
bondage

SUSTAINED PRACTICE (abhyāsa) + DISPASSION (vairāgya) -> increasingly stable restraint

In simple words: Yoga does not say every thought is false. It says every thought is a changing form of mind-field (citta). True cognition can help liberation, but final freedom requires ending identification with all mental forms.

Vṛtti	Simple meaning
Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	Valid cognition
Viparyaya	Error
Vikalpa	Words without corresponding object
Nidra	Sleep-mode
Smṛti	Memory

Memory line: truth can be a ladder, but the witness is not the ladder.

2. CITTAVṚTTI

2.1 Statement

- FACT: **Cittavṛtti** (cittavṛtti) means a modification, fluctuation or operative mode of mind-field (citta).
- FACT: Yoga holds that mind-field (citta) constantly assumes forms corresponding to objects, memories, errors, absences and verbal constructions.
- FACT: These modifications are the immediate field of bondage because the reflected self falsely identifies with them.

2.2 Foundational sūtra

- FACT: The defining statement of the system is: "**Yogaś-citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ**" - Yoga is the restraint of the modifications of mind-field (citta).
- FACT: The immediately following implication is: "**tadā draṣṭuḥ svarūpe'vasthānam**" - then the seer abides in its own nature.
- ANALYSIS: These two aphorisms together explain the entire logic of Yoga: control is not an end in itself; it is required because only when vṛttis cease does conscious witness (puruṣa) stand free of misidentification.

2.3 Why is cessation prescribed?

1. FACT: Mind-field (citta), by its nature, takes the form of whatever it attends to.
 2. FACT: Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s consciousness is reflected in mind-field (citta).
 3. FACT: In ignorance, the self appropriates these changing forms as "I know," "I suffer," "I desire," "I remember."
 4. FACT: Therefore the stream of vṛttis sustains bondage.
 5. FACT: Their restraint uncovers the already-free nature of the seer.
- ANALYSIS: A safe image is the clear pool: when ripples settle, the water reflects without distortion; when mental modifications (citta-vṛttis) settle, conscious witness (puruṣa) is no longer misread through mental turbulence.
 - ANALYSIS: Thus **nirodha** is revelatory, not destructive: it removes concealment, not consciousness.

2.4 The five vṛttis

- FACT: Patañjali classifies all modifications into **five kinds**.
- FACT: Each may be either **kliṣṭa** or **akliṣṭa** depending on whether it sustains affliction or aids release.

Vṛtti	Definition	Example	Philosophical note
Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	valid cognition	seeing smoke and correctly inferring fire	even true knowledge is still a modification
Viparyaya	error or misconception	taking nacre for silver	false cognition distorts conduct
Vikalpa	verbal or conceptual construction without real object	"the horn of a hare"	language can move without ontic referent
Nidrā	sleep as a positive mental mode grounded in absence-content	awareness later reported as "I slept"	even sleep is not non-mental blankness
Smṛti	memory	recollection of past pain or pleasure	retained traces re-present prior experience

2.5 Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) as vṛtti

- FACT: Yoga does not deny valid cognition; it includes it as one kind of vṛtti.
- FACT: The accepted forms of means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) are perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna) and **āgama/verbal testimony (śabda)** (authoritative testimony).
- FACT: This aligns Yoga with the three-pramāṇa scheme of Sāṃkhya.
- ANALYSIS: Exam point: because even valid cognition is still a citta-modification, Yoga seeks not endless conceptual accumulation but eventual stilling.
- ANALYSIS: Cross-reference: see Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) across schools.

2.6 Viparyaya

- FACT: **Viparyaya** is false knowledge not corresponding to the object as it is.
- FACT: It includes perceptual and conceptual misapprehension.
- ANALYSIS: Since error reinforces wrong attachment and aversion, it is typically **kliṣṭa**.

2.7 Vikalpa

- FACT: **Vikalpa** is cognition produced by words alone where no corresponding object exists.
- FACT: It is not sheer nonsense; it has linguistic intelligibility without objective referent.
- ANALYSIS: Yoga is sensitive to the autonomous power of language to create mental worlds, anxieties, dogmas and imagined identities.

2.8 Nidrā

- FACT: Sleep is treated as a positive *vṛtti* rather than a mere absence.
- FACT: Later recollection - "I slept and knew nothing" - shows that sleep leaves a determinate mental trace.
- ANALYSIS: Philosophically, Yoga refuses to equate quiescence with liberation: mere sleep suppresses activity, but does not produce discriminative freedom.

2.9 Smṛti

- FACT: Memory is the re-presentation of past experience without complete loss of its prior content.
- FACT: *Smṛti* links past impressions to present identity and reaction.
- ANALYSIS: In practical psychology, memory feeds attachment, trauma, fear and habitual self-narration.

2.10 Kliṣṭa and akliṣṭa vṛttis

- FACT: Each of the five *vṛttis* can be either **kliṣṭa** (afflicted) or **akliṣṭa** (non-afflicted).
- FACT: **Kliṣṭa vṛttis** are those coloured by ignorance (*avidyā*) and the other afflictions (*kleśas*) and hence productive of bondage.
- FACT: **Akliṣṭa vṛttis** are those purified and redirected toward discrimination, detachment and liberation.
- ANALYSIS: For example, valid cognition of impermanence, disciplined scriptural reflection or recollection aiding practice may be *akliṣṭa*, while the same broad *vṛtti*-types in service of vanity or desire remain *kliṣṭa*.

2.11 Why this distinction matters

- FACT: Yoga does not begin by abolishing all cognition at once.
- FACT: It first transforms the quality of mental life, replacing afflicted modifications by non-afflicted ones.
- ANALYSIS: *Akliṣṭa vṛttis* are therapeutic instruments that ultimately subside once their work is done.

2.12 Means of restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha)

- FACT: The basic means are sustained practice (*abhyāsa*) and **dispassion (vairāgya)** (detachment).
- FACT: Preparatory discipline (*kriyā-yoga*) weakens afflictive forces.
- FACT: Eight-limbed discipline (*aṣṭāṅga-yoga*) progressively disciplines the body-sense-mind complex.
- FACT: Dedication to the Lord (*īśvara-praṇidhāna*) offers a theistic aid to concentration and obstacle-removal.
- ANALYSIS: Thus *nirodha* is methodical, not abrupt.

2.13 Cittavṛtti and the 2023 demand

- FACT: The 2023 question asked both **what mind-field (citta) and its modifications are** and **why cessation is prescribed**.
- ANALYSIS: The ideal answer must therefore move in three steps: define mind-field (*citta*), list the five *vṛttis*, and explain *nirodha* through the misidentification of conscious witness (*puruṣa*) with mind-field (*citta*).

2.14 Cittavṛtti and the 2024 demand

- FACT: The 2024 wording emphasized that as long as mind-field (*citta*) changes, the self is reflected therein and identifies itself with those changes in the absence of discriminative knowledge.
- ANALYSIS: This directly joins §1 and §2: the question is not about mental mechanics alone but about Yoga's full **soteriology of reflection, confusion and restraint**.

2.15 Mini-conclusion on cittavṛtti

- ANALYSIS: In exam language: **mental modifications (citta-vṛttis) are the dynamic forms assumed by the mind-complex; they must be restrained because their ongoing operation sustains the false identification of the seer with the seen.**

2.16 Citta-pariṇāma - transformation of the mental substrate

Statement. FACT: **Citta-pariṇāma** (citta-parinama; transformation of citta) is Yoga's account of how the mind-complex really changes across practice without destroying its continuity as a prakṛtic substrate.

Argument.

1. FACT: The Vibhūti-pāda tradition recognises three specifically yogic transformations of mind-field (citta): **nirodha-pariṇāma**, **samādhi-pariṇāma** and **ekāgratā-pariṇāma**.
2. FACT: **Nirodha-pariṇāma** is the transformation in which impressions of restraint increasingly overpower impressions of emergence; the mind becomes habituated to cessation rather than dispersion.
3. FACT: **Samādhi-pariṇāma** is the transformation from many-pointedness to unified absorption; the distracting multiplicity of contents weakens while one object becomes dominant.
4. FACT: **Ekāgratā-pariṇāma** is the transformation of one-pointed continuity, where similar cognitive moments arise and subside in an unbroken stream toward the same object.
5. FACT: Yoga also accepts a general threefold transformation of any substrate: **dharma-pariṇāma** (dharma-parinama; change of property), **lakṣaṇa-pariṇāma** (laksana-parinama; change of temporal character) and **avasthā-pariṇāma** (avastha-parinama; change of condition or state).
6. FACT: These transformations presuppose a **dharmin** (dharmin; persisting substrate) that undergoes changes of property, temporal phase and condition without becoming sheer momentary flashes.
7. ANALYSIS: This is philosophically necessary because Yoga inherits Sāṃkhya **real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)** (parinamavada; real transformation): mind-field (citta) really changes, and the path's graded progress would be unintelligible if there were no continuing mental substrate.

Presupposition. FACT: The doctrine presupposes that primordial material nature (prakṛti) and its evolutes are real and transformable, while conscious witness (puruṣa) remains unmodified witness-consciousness.

Example. ANALYSIS: The same lake can be stormy, gradually calming, and finally still; the states differ, yet the lake-substrate persists. Likewise mind-field (citta) can pass from restless mind (kṣipta) to one-pointed mind (ekāgra) to fully restrained mind (niruddha) without becoming a new self.

Objection. ANALYSIS: A Buddhist **kṣaṇikavādin** (ksanikavadin; momentarist) may argue that only a stream of momentary events is needed; a persisting citta-substrate is an unnecessary fiction.

Reply. FACT: Yoga answers that practice, memory, saṃskāra-continuity and stable meditative acquisition require more than disconnected flashes. ANALYSIS: Both Yoga and Buddhism admit ceaseless change, but Yoga retains a persisting prakṛtic substrate, whereas Buddhist **kṣaṇikavāda** (ksanikavada; momentariness) denies enduring mental substance.

Comparison	Yoga's position	Exam contrast
FACT: Yoga's real transformation (pariṇāmavāda) vs Buddhist kṣaṇikavāda	FACT: Real change occurs in a continuing mind-field (citta)/dharmin.	ANALYSIS: Buddhism can explain flow without a substrate; Yoga needs substrate for saṃskāra and graded discipline.
FACT: Yoga's real transformation (pariṇāmavāda) vs Advaita vivartavāda (vivartavada; apparent transformation)	FACT: Change in mind-field (citta)/primordial material nature (prakṛti) is real, not merely apparent.	ANALYSIS: Advaita makes ultimate reality non-transforming Brahman; Yoga keeps real prakṛtic change and many conscious witness (puruṣas).

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind
->
2. CITTAVṚTTI
->
2.1 Statement
->
2.2 Foundational sūtra
->
UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

Plain-language visual - diagnosis and treatment

IGNORANCE (avidyā)
|
EGO-IDENTIFICATION (asmitā) -> ATTACHMENT (rāga) / AVERSION (dveṣa) -> CLINGING TO LIFE (abhiniveśa)
|
ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (karma) -> DEPOSIT -> FRUITION -> REBIRTH

ETHICAL RESTRAINT (yama) + OBSERVANCE (niyama) + POSTURE (āsana) + BREATH REGULATION (prāṇāyāma)
+ SENSE WITHDRAWAL (pratyāhāra) + CONCENTRATION (dhāraṇā) + MEDITATION (dhyāna) +
MEDITATIVE ABSORPTION (samādhi)
|
weaken and burn the causes

In simple words: Yoga treats bondage as a causal illness. Ignorance produces ego-identification, attachment, aversion and fear; these colour action and continue the cycle. The eight limbs transform conduct, embodiment and attention at progressively deeper levels.

Memory line: ethics calms the causes that meditation must finally uproot.

3. AFFLICTIONS (kleśas)

3.1 Statement

- FACT: **Afflictions (kleśas)** (klesas) are the afflictions that poison mind-field (citta), generate action and moral consequence (karma) and sustain saṃsāric bondage.
- FACT: They are deeper than surface thoughts: they are the causal colouring of mental life.
- FACT: Yoga lists **five afflictions (kleśas)**, with **ignorance (avidyā)** as the root.

3.2 The five afflictions (kleśas) at a glance

Affliction (kleśa)	Core meaning	Why it binds
Ignorance (avidyā)	ignorance, misapprehension of reality	root of all other afflictions
Ego-identification (asmitā)	egoity, I-am-ness	confuses conscious witness (puruṣa) with determinative intellect (buddhi)
Attachment (rāga)	attachment	pursues pleasure and repetition
Aversion (dveṣa)	aversion	flees pain and breeds hostility
Clinging to life (abhiniveśa)	clinging to life / fear of death	instinctive self-preservation binds the stream

3.3 Ignorance (avidyā) as the root

- FACT: Ignorance (avidyā) is specifically defined as mistaking:
 - the **non-eternal** for the eternal,
 - the **impure** for the pure,
 - the **painful** for the pleasant,

- the **non-self** for the self.
- FACT: It is the matrix from which all other afflictions (kleśas) arise.
- ANALYSIS: Ignorance (avidyā) in Yoga is not merely lack of information; it is a pervasive existential misorientation.

3.4 Ego-identification (asmitā)

- FACT: **Ego-identification (asmitā)** is the confusion of the seer with the instrument of seeing.
- FACT: More precisely, it is the identification of **conscious witness (puruṣa)** with **determinative intellect (buddhi)** or the internal organ.
- ANALYSIS: The ego says, "I think, I act, I suffer," because it cannot distinguish consciousness from its reflected vehicle.

3.5 Attachment (rāga)

- FACT: **Attachment (rāga)** is attachment arising from remembered pleasure.
- FACT: It pushes mind-field (citta) toward repetition and possession.
- ANALYSIS: In practical life, attachment (rāga) keeps the mind outward-turned and dependent on conditions.

3.6 Aversion (dveṣa)

- FACT: **Aversion (dveṣa)** is aversion arising from remembered pain.
- FACT: It is the negative counterpart of attachment (rāga).
- ANALYSIS: Together attachment (rāga) and aversion (dveṣa) structure most reactive life: chasing the agreeable, fleeing the disagreeable.

3.7 Clinging to life (abhiniveśa)

- FACT: **Clinging to life (abhiniveśa)** is clinging to life, often expressed as fear of death.
- FACT: Yoga stresses that it is present **even in the learned**.
- ANALYSIS: This is a subtle and frequently tested point: clinging to life (abhiniveśa) is not merely an intellectual error, but a deeply rooted instinctive attachment carried by latent impressions.

3.8 The four states of afflictions (kleśas)

- FACT: Afflictions (kleśas) do not always function at the same intensity.
- FACT: Tradition describes **four states**.

State	Meaning	Illustration
Prasupta	dormant	seed-like, not presently manifest
Tanu	attenuated	weakened by discipline and insight
Vicchinna	interrupted	temporarily suppressed by opposing forces
Udāra	active, expanded	fully operative in conduct and reaction

3.9 Explanation of the four states

(a) Prasupta

- FACT: The affliction (kleśa) remains in latency.
- ANALYSIS: Dormancy is not destruction; favourable conditions can reactivate it.

(b) Tanu

- FACT: Through practice, austerity, meditation and discernment, afflictions are thinned out.
- ANALYSIS: This is the desirable middle state in disciplined progress.

(c) Vicchinna

- FACT: An affliction can be temporarily interrupted by the operation of another tendency.
- ANALYSIS: For example, attachment may seem absent only because fear is presently stronger.

(d) Udāra

- FACT: The affliction (kleśa) becomes active and behaviour-shaping.
- ANALYSIS: Here it visibly governs speech, action and affect.

3.10 Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) as first therapy of afflictions (kleśas)

- FACT: Patañjali prescribes **preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga)** as consisting of:
 1. **tapas** - disciplined austerity or heat-generating effort,
 2. **svādhyāya** - self-study and/or recitation-study of sacred teaching,
 3. **Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna)** - surrender or devotion to Lord (Īśvara).
- FACT: Its explicit purpose is to **attenuate afflictions (kleśas)** and prepare for meditative absorption (samādhi).
- ANALYSIS: Thus Yoga begins not from abstract metaphysics alone but from deliberate re-education of habit and motive.

3.11 Meditation (dhyāna) as deeper burning of afflictions (kleśas)

- FACT: Gross kleśa-expressions are weakened by ethical and practical discipline.
- FACT: Their subtle forms (**sūkṣma**) are burned through **meditation (dhyāna)** and higher meditative absorption.
- ANALYSIS: This explains why mere moral restraint is insufficient: latent affliction survives unless its causal seed is scorched.

3.12 Causal chain of bondage

- FACT: The afflictive mechanism may be summarised as:

Afflictions (kleśas) → Action and moral consequence (karma) → Vipāka → Āśaya → Punarjanma

- FACT: **Afflictions (kleśas)** motivate action.
- FACT: Action deposits karmic force.
- FACT: Action and moral consequence (karma) ripens as **vipāka** (fruition).
- FACT: The residual store becomes **āśaya** or karmic deposit.
- FACT: This fuels further birth and suffering.
- ANALYSIS: The chain shows why Yoga is not satisfied with external behaviour-management; it aims at the root-affliction itself.

3.13 Action and moral consequence (karma) and vipāka - kleśa-rooted moral causation

Statement. FACT: **Karmāśaya** (karmashaya; karmic deposit or stock) is the subtle store of action-traces rooted in afflictions (kleśas), and **vipāka** (vipaka; fruition) is its ripening as concrete embodied experience.

Argument.

1. FACT: The karmic deposit is **kleśa-mūla** (klesha-mula; rooted in the afflictions): action binds because it is coloured by ignorance (avidyā), ego-identification (asmitā), attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa) and clinging to life (abhiniveśa).
2. FACT: Vipāka is classically threefold: **jāti** (jati; birth or species-condition), **āyus** (ayus; life-span) and **bhoga** (bhoga; experience/enjoyment-suffering).
3. FACT: **Vāsanā** (vasana; latent tendency) and **saṃskāra** (samskara; impression) explain continuity: repeated cognition and action leave traces, traces dispose future cognition and action, and the cycle becomes morally structured.
4. FACT: Yoga classifies action and moral consequence (karma) as **śukla** (shukla; white), **kṛṣṇa** (krishna; black), **śukla-kṛṣṇa** (mixed white-black) and **aśukla-akṛṣṇa** (ashukla-akrishna; neither white nor black), the last being associated with the yogin whose action no longer produces ordinary bondage.
5. ANALYSIS: This matters philosophically because Yoga is not merely therapeutic psychology; it explains how psychological purification can have soteriological effect by interrupting the moral-causal engine of rebirth.
6. ANALYSIS: Therefore kleśa-attenuation (**tanū-karaṇa**, tanu-karana; thinning) and final **reverse evolution (pratiprasava)** (reabsorption into the cause) are the real targets, not temporary emotional calm.

Presupposition. FACT: Yoga presupposes a morally ordered cosmos in which subtle mental-affective causes can ripen beyond a single visible episode of experience.

Example. FACT: The **dagdha-bīja** (dagdha-bija; burnt seed) image is exam-safe: a burnt seed may retain seed-shape, but it cannot germinate; similarly attenuated and burnt afflictions (kleśas) lose karmic fertility.

Objection. ANALYSIS: If liberation depends on exhausting an unsurveyable stock of karmāśaya, release seems indefinitely postponed.

Reply. FACT: Yoga replies that liberating knowledge and meditative absorption (samādhi) burn the seeds of future bondage. **ANALYSIS:** Using later comparative vocabulary, only **prārabdha-type** (prarabdha-type; already-fructifying) embodiment continues until its momentum is spent, like a potter's wheel turning briefly after the potter stops pushing.

3.14 Why removal of afflictions (kleśas) leads to isolation (kaivalya)

1. **FACT:** Afflictions (kleśas) are the roots of karmically binding activity.
 2. **FACT:** Without afflictions (kleśas), karmic production and karmic reactivation cease.
 3. **FACT:** Without karmic deposit, the machinery of repeated birth collapses.
 4. **FACT:** As mind-field (citta) is purified and discrimination matures, meditative absorption (samādhi) becomes stable.
 5. **FACT:** This culminates in isolation (kaivalya).
- **ANALYSIS:** The 2021 20-marker demanded precisely this transition from **diagnosis of affliction** to **logic of liberation**.

3.15 Affliction (kleśa) and error across schools

School	Root problem	Yoga's distinctive feature
Buddhism	ignorance (avidyā) + tṛṣṇā	Yoga keeps enduring conscious witness (puruṣa) and citta-psychology
Sāṃkhya	aviveka between conscious witness (puruṣa) and primordial material nature (prakṛti)	Yoga adds meditative psychology and Lord (Īśvara)
Advaita Vedānta	ignorance (avidyā)/adhyāsa	Yoga has no Brahman-identity thesis
Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	mithyājñāna	Yoga stresses affective affliction and meditative remedy

3.16 Mini-conclusion on afflictions (kleśas)

- **ANALYSIS:** A compact answer-line: **afflictions (kleśas) are the afflictive roots of cycle of rebirth (saṃsāra), with ignorance (avidyā) as the source and preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) plus meditation as the means of attenuation and destruction.**

4. AṢṬĀṄGA YOGA

4.1 Why include eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga) here?

- **FACT:** Though the syllabus clause names mind-field (citta), cittavṛtti, afflictions (kleśas), meditative absorption (samādhi) and isolation (kaivalya), the path linking them is the **aṣṭāṅga** discipline.
- **FACT:** UPSC often expects the mediating practical architecture in any fuller answer on Yoga.
- **ANALYSIS:** The point is philosophical significance, not physical drill.

4.2 The eight limbs

Limb	Basic meaning	Group	Philosophical significance
Ethical restraint (yama)	restraints	bahiraṅga	social-ethical purification of conduct
Observance (niyama)	observances	bahiraṅga	positive self-cultivation and inner orientation
Posture (āsana)	posture	bahiraṅga	embodied steadiness enabling meditative work
Breath regulation (prāṇāyāma)	regulation of breath-life-force	bahiraṅga	calms psycho-physical disturbance
Sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra)	withdrawal of senses	bahiraṅga / bridge	de-links mind-field (citta) from compulsive object-pursuit
Concentration (dhāraṇā)	concentration	antaraṅga	fixing attention on one locus
Meditation (dhyāna)	meditation	antaraṅga	continuous flow toward the object
Meditative absorption (samādhi)	absorption	antaraṅga	consummated identity of attention with support

4.3 Bahiraṅga and antaraṅga

- FACT: The first five are called **bahiraṅga** - external limbs.
- FACT: The last three are **antaraṅga** - internal limbs.
- ANALYSIS: "External" does not mean unimportant; it means preparatory with respect to the subtler operations of meditative consciousness.

4.4 Ethical restraint (yama)

- FACT: The **ethical restraint (yamas)** are the great restraints governing relation to others and to desire.
- FACT: The classical list is:
 1. **ahiṃsā** - non-violence,
 2. **satya** - truthfulness,
 3. **asteya** - non-stealing,
 4. **brahmacarya** - chastity / disciplined energy,
 5. **aparigraha** - non-possessiveness.
- ANALYSIS: Philosophically, ethical restraint (yama) reduces the rajasic-tāmasic turbulence that continually destabilizes mind-field (citta).

4.5 Observance (niyama)

- FACT: The **observance (niyamas)** are positive observances:
 1. **śauca** - purity,
 2. **santoṣa** - contentment,
 3. **tapas** - disciplined austerity,
 4. **svādhyāya** - self-study/scriptural recitation,
 5. **Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna)** - surrender to Lord (Īśvara).
- ANALYSIS: Observance (niyama) gives inward form to ethical discipline and opens the mind-field (citta) toward reflective and devotional stabilization.

4.6 Posture (āsana)

- FACT: Posture (āsana) in classical Yoga is primarily the establishment of a **steady and comfortable posture**.
- ANALYSIS: Its significance is not gymnastic display but freedom from bodily distraction.
- ANALYSIS: A body at war with itself becomes an obstacle to meditative one-pointedness.

4.7 Breath regulation (prāṇāyāma)

- FACT: Breath regulation (prāṇāyāma) regulates breathing and, through it, the psycho-physical economy.

- ANALYSIS: Breath functions as a hinge between body and mind-field (citta); its refinement steadies attention and weakens agitation.

4.8 Sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra)

- FACT: Sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra) is withdrawal of the senses from their objects.
- ANALYSIS: It is not mutilation of sensory life but release from compulsive extroversion.
- ANALYSIS: This is the transition from ethical-embodied preparation to explicitly internal yogic work.

4.9 Concentration (dhāraṇā)

- FACT: Concentration (dhāraṇā) is concentration: binding mind-field (citta) to a chosen locus.
- ANALYSIS: It is the initial stabilization of attention and the first clear sign of **ekāgratā**.

4.10 Meditation (dhyāna)

- FACT: Meditation (dhyāna) is uninterrupted flow of cognition toward that same object.
- ANALYSIS: Unlike concentration (dhāraṇā)'s effortful fixing, meditation (dhyāna) is sustained continuity.
- FACT: It is also a direct means for thinning and burning subtle afflictions (kleśas).

4.11 Meditative absorption (samādhi)

- FACT: Meditative absorption (samādhi) is the culmination of meditative integration wherein the object alone shines with minimal interference from discursiveness.
- ANALYSIS: Because meditative absorption (samādhi) is itself a syllabus-term, it receives separate detailed treatment in §5 below.

4.12 Integrated concentration (saṃyama)

- FACT: **Integrated concentration (saṃyama)** is the integrated operation of **concentration (dhāraṇā) + meditation (dhyāna) + meditative absorption (samādhi)** on one object.
- FACT: It represents the inner technical core of Yoga's contemplative method.
- ANALYSIS: Philosophically, integrated concentration (saṃyama) is the progressive refinement of intentionality until cognition becomes translucent to the structure of its object.

4.13 Eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga) as psychology of liberation

- ANALYSIS: The eight limbs are best read as a graded transformation:
 - ethics cures gross disturbance,
 - posture and breath calm embodiment,
 - withdrawal cuts sensory dispersion,
 - concentration and meditation unify the mental stream,
 - meditative absorption (samādhi) prepares discriminative liberation.
- ANALYSIS: Thus eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga) operationalizes the abstract definition of Yoga as restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha).

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

->

3. AFFLICTIONS (kleśas)

->

3.1 Statement

->

3.2 The five afflictions (kleśas) at a glance

->

UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control

Plain-language visual - increasingly transparent attention

ordinary mind -> one-pointed attention -> object-supported absorption
-> beyond objectification
-> even residual seed ceases

SAMPRAJNATA: cognitive support remains

ASAMPRAJNATA: vṛttis cease, saṃskāra may remain

NIRBĪJA: even residual seed is restrained

In simple words: Meditative absorption (samādhi) is not sleep. It is the disciplined refinement of attention until mind-field (citta) becomes transparent and finally ceases producing binding object-forms.

YS 1.17 factors: vitarka, vicāra, ānanda, ego-identification (asmitā)

YS 1.42-1.44 samāpattis: savitarka/nirvitarka,
savicāra/nirvicāra

These are related grids, not the same list.

Memory line: preserve the classification before explaining the ascent.

5. MEDITATIVE ABSORPTION (samādhi)

5.1 Statement

- FACT: **Meditative absorption (samādhi)** (samadhi) is meditative absorption in which mind-field (citta) becomes radically unified and transparent.
- FACT: It is not mere passivity; it is the highest refinement of attention and the threshold of liberating discernment.
- FACT: Classical Yoga distinguishes two main forms: **samprajñāta** and **asamprajñāta** meditative absorption (samādhi).

5.2 Object-supported absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) - with object / with seed

- FACT: **Object-supported absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi)** is cognitive or object-oriented absorption.
- FACT: A support remains; there is still a subtle seed of cognition.
- FACT: It is called **sabīja** (YS 1.46) because an object-support ("seed") is still present.
- ANALYSIS: **Two senses of "seed" must be kept apart:** in YS 1.46 *sabīja* means "with object-support", whereas the *bīja* denied in *nirbīja* at YS 1.51 is the residual **saṃskāra**. Losing the object-support therefore does not by itself make a meditative absorption (samādhi) *nirbīja*.
- ANALYSIS: The mind is profoundly stilled, but not utterly free of object-reference.

5.3 Two canonical schemes that must not be conflated

- FACT: Pātañjala Yoga uses two related but distinct classifications in the Samādhi-pāda.
- FACT: **Yogasūtra 1.17** defines **samprajñāta** meditative absorption (samādhi) through four accompanying factors: **vitarka, vicāra, ānanda, ego-identification (asmitā)** - *vitarka-vicārānandāsmītā-rūpānugamāt samprajñātaḥ*.
- FACT: **Yogasūtra 1.42-1.44** classifies **samāpatti** (samapatti; meditative coalescence with an object) as **savitarkā/nirvitarkā** and **savicārā/nirvicārā**.
- ANALYSIS: The first scheme answers: "What characterises object-supported absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi)?" The second answers: "How does object-absorption differ according to conceptual-verbal overlay and object-level?"

5.4 YS 1.17: the fourfold character of object-supported absorption (sampprajñāta-samādhi)

Factor in samprajñāta	Object-level / cognitive tone	Safe explanation
FACT: Vitarka	FACT: gross object-level engagement	FACT: absorption still accompanied by gross deliberative grasp.
FACT: Vicāra	FACT: subtle object-level reflection	FACT: attention moves from gross entities toward subtle principles.
FACT: Ānanda	FACT: refined sattvic joy/bliss-aspect	ANALYSIS: not ordinary pleasure; it is a purified meditative affect attached to sattva.
FACT: Ego-identification (asmitā)	FACT: bare "I-am-ness"	ANALYSIS: not the ordinary kleśa-asmitā in its binding form, but the extremely subtle objectification of the I-sense.

- FACT: Therefore **sānanda** and **sāsmīta** are not a contested addition to Patañjali's list; **ānanda** and **ego-identification (asmitā)** are explicitly present in the sūtra's own fourfold characterisation.
- ANALYSIS: What becomes interpretively delicate is not whether ānanda and ego-identification (asmitā) belong to samprajñāta, but how later commentators map them onto the samāpatti sequence.

5.5 YS 1.42-1.46: samāpatti-bhedas, not the YS 1.17 fourfold list

Samāpatti-bheda	Object-range	Conceptual-verbal overlay	Doctrinal point
FACT: Savitarkā samāpatti	FACT: gross (sthūla) object	FACT: mixed with śabda-artha-jñāna-vikalpa (word-object-knowledge construction)	FACT: absorption still carries name, meaning and concept together.
FACT: Nirvitarkā samāpatti	FACT: gross object	FACT: memory and verbal construction are purified	FACT: the object shines more immediately without gross conceptual overlay.
FACT: Savicārā samāpatti	FACT: subtle (sūkṣma) object	FACT: subtle reflective consideration remains	FACT: absorption turns from gross objects to subtle principles.
FACT: Nirvicārā samāpatti	FACT: subtle object	FACT: even subtle reflective overlay is stilled	FACT: refined subtle-object absorption becomes luminous and clear.

- FACT: Under YS 1.44, the **savicārā/nirvicārā** pair is stated with reference to subtle objects.
- FACT: YS 1.45 extends the subtle domain up to **aliṅga** (alinga; the undifferentiated prakṛtic condition).
- FACT: YS 1.46 states that these samāpattis remain **sabīja** (sabija; with seed) meditative absorption (samādhi).
- FACT: YS 1.47 says the clarity (**vaiśāradya**, vaisaradya; lucidity) of **nirvicārā** leads to **adhyātma-prasāda** (adhyatma-prasada; inner clarity of the self-field).
- FACT: YS 1.48 says that therein the prajñā is **ṛtambharā** (rtambhara; truth-bearing).
- FACT: **Example.** The crystal (**sphaṭika**) taking the colour of a nearby flower captures samāpatti: mind-field (citta) becomes so object-coloured that the object seems to shine through it.

5.6 Reconciliation: how commentators relate the two schemes

Statement. FACT: The safe reconciliation is: **vitarka-vicāra-ānanda-asmitā** are the canonical four factors of samprajñāta, while **savitarkā/nirvitarkā/savicārā/nirvicārā** are samāpatti varieties within object-supported absorption.

Argument.

1. FACT: The sa/nir- distinction concerns whether conceptual-verbal overlay (**vikalpa**, especially **śabda-artha-jñāna-vikalpa**) is present or absent in absorption.
2. FACT: The vitarka/vicāra/ānanda/ego-identification (asmitā) series concerns the level or refinement of the object/support on which samprajñāta rests: gross -> subtle -> sattva-bliss aspect -> bare I-am-ness.
3. ANALYSIS: Vyāsa's **Yogabhāṣya** and later Vācaspati Miśra and Vijñānabhikṣu attempt to map these two analytic grids onto one graded meditative path.

4. CAUTION: Commentarial differences remain over whether **ānanda** and **ego-identification (asmitā)** should be counted as independent samāpattis, as supervening aspects of the subtle stage, or as higher refinements beyond the four named sa/nir samāpattis.

Presupposition. FACT: The reconciliation presupposes that Patañjali can classify the same meditative ascent by different criteria: object-level, cognitive factor, and degree of conceptual purification.

Example. ANALYSIS: A student may compare it to classifying the same university course by year-level and by assessment-mode: the grids overlap, but they are not the same list.

Objection. ANALYSIS: If both schemes operate within sabīja absorption, why not simply call savitarkā, nirvitarkā, savicārā and nirvicārā the four samprajñāta stages?

Reply. FACT: Because YS 1.17 itself names the four factors of samprajñāta as vitarka, vicāra, ānanda and ego-identification (asmitā); the sa/nir list belongs to the later samāpatti analysis of gross and subtle object-absorption.

Safe examination formula. ANALYSIS: Write: "Patañjali characterises samprajñāta by vitarka, vicāra, ānanda and ego-identification (asmitā). He then analyses samāpatti as savitarkā/nirvitarkā for gross objects and savicārā/nirvicārā for subtle objects. Commentators map these schemes, but the lists should not be conflated."

5.7 Trap box: samprajñāta vs samāpatti lists

DO NOT WRITE:

"The four types of object-supported absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) listed by Patañjali are savitarka, nirvitarka, savicāra and nirvicāra."

WRITE INSTEAD:

YS 1.17 fourfold samprajñāta = vitarka + vicāra + ānanda + ego-identification (asmitā).

YS 1.42-1.44 samāpatti-bhedas = savitarkā/nirvitarkā and savicārā/nirvicārā.

5.8 Ṛtambharā prajñā - truth-bearing insight

Statement. FACT: **Ṛtambharā prajñā** (rtambhara prajna; truth-bearing insight) is the special lucidity arising with **nirvicāra-vaiśāradya** (nirvicara-vaisharadya; clarity of subtle absorption), where mind-field (citta) grasps the object with exceptional purity.

Argument.

1. FACT: It is linked to **adhyātma-prasāda**, the inward clarity that follows the perfection of nirvicārā samāpatti.
2. FACT: It differs from **śruta** (sruta; scriptural/testimonial knowledge) and **inference (anumāna)** (anumana; inference), because those normally reach universals or general relations, while ṛtambharā has a **viśeṣa-artha** (visesa-artha; particular object) as its field.
3. FACT: Thus yogic insight reaches the individual/particular in a way ordinary testimony and inference do not.
4. FACT: Its saṃskāra obstructs other saṃskāras: the impression born of truth-bearing insight counteracts ordinary afflicted and dispersive impressions.
5. FACT: When even the saṃskāra of ṛtambharā ceases, seedless absorption (**nirbīja samādhi**, YS 1.51) becomes possible.
6. FACT: Yoga accepts three means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) - **perception (pratyakṣa)**, **inference (anumāna)** and **āgama/verbal testimony (śabda)** - so ṛtambharā is not a fourth means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).
7. ANALYSIS: It is best classified as perfected **yogi-pratyakṣa** (yogi-pratyaksa; extraordinary yogic perception), an extraordinary refinement of perception rather than a new independent means of knowledge.

Presupposition. FACT: Yoga presupposes that mind-field (citta) can become so sattva-pure that perception is no longer distorted by ordinary conceptual, affective and karmic deposits.

Example. ANALYSIS: Ordinary inference knows "fire is present because smoke is present" as a general relation; ṛtambharā is like direct yogic disclosure of the concrete object in its particularity, without dependence on discursive mediation.

Objection. ANALYSIS: If ṛtambharā is still a mental modification (citta-vṛtti), how can it help liberation rather than bind?

Reply. FACT: Yoga replies that *akliṣṭa vṛttis* can cancel *kliṣṭa vṛttis*; the truth-bearing impression blocks lower impressions and then itself ceases. ANALYSIS: It is a ladder that must finally be left behind.

Caution. ANALYSIS: Do not simply equate *ṛtambharā* with Aurobindo's "knowledge by identity" or "supermind". The resemblance is thematic only: in Yoga, *ṛtambharā* is a purified mental modification (*citta-vṛtti*) that must finally cease; in Aurobindo, supramental knowledge by identity is reinterpreted as a permanent, world-affirming gnosis.

5.9 Objectless absorption (*asamprajñāta-samādhi*) - beyond cognitive objectification

- FACT: **Objectless absorption (*asamprajñāta-samādhi*)** is non-cognitive or supra-cognitive absorption in which the *vṛttis* cease and no object stands forth as support in the ordinary sense.
- FACT: **YS 1.18** defines it as *virāma-pratyaya-abhyāsa-pūrvah saṁskāra-śeṣo 'nyaḥ* - "the other [meditative absorption (*samādhi*)] is preceded by the practice of the idea of cessation, and **has *saṁskāra* as its residue.**"
- FACT: So on the *sūtra*'s own wording *asamprajñāta* is characterised by ***saṁskāra-śeṣa***: latent impressions may still remain even though cognitive absorption has stopped.
- ANALYSIS: It is crucial not to confuse this with sleep or blank unconsciousness; it is the fruition of radical meditative restraint.

5.9A Seedless absorption (*nirbīja-samādhi*) - when even the residual seed ceases

- FACT: **YS 1.51** states *tasyāpi nirodhe sarva-nirodhān nirbījaḥ samādhiḥ* - "on the restraint of **that too**, everything being restrained, meditative absorption (*samādhi*) is **seedless.**"
- FACT: The "that too" is the residual impression left by the preceding stage (the *saṁskāra* born of *ṛtambharā prajñā*, YS 1.50); when even it is restrained, absorption becomes ***nirbīja***.
- ANALYSIS: **Do not equate the two terms.** *Asamprajñāta* (YS 1.18) is defined by *residual saṁskāra*; *nirbīja* (YS 1.51) is defined by *the cessation of even that residue*. *Nirbīja* is best treated as the culminating condition reached within the *asamprajñāta* phase, not as a synonym for it.
- ANALYSIS: FACT: Safe answer formula: *asamprajñāta* = *vṛttis stopped*, *saṁskāra-śeṣa* remains; *nirbīja* = *even that residual saṁskāra restrained*.

5.10 Relation between *saṁskāra* and *nirodha*

- FACT: Even when active *vṛttis* cease, latent impressions can remain as residual potency - this is exactly the *saṁskāra-śeṣa* of YS 1.18.
- FACT: Hence the path must proceed beyond surface quietness to the restraint of even the subtle seed, which is what YS 1.51 marks as *nirbīja*.
- ANALYSIS: This explains why temporary calm or trance is not yet liberation.

5.11 Cloud-of-virtue absorption (*dharmamegha-samādhi*)

- FACT: **Cloud-of-virtue absorption (*dharmamegha-samādhi*)** is the highest meditative absorption (*samādhi*) immediately preceding isolation (*kaivalya*).
- FACT: The image is that of a **cloud of dharma** raining down the fullness of discriminative knowledge.
- FACT: At this level, even fascination with extraordinary knowledge or powers is relinquished.
- ANALYSIS: It marks the consummation of non-attachment: the yogin no longer seeks omniscience, attainment or display.

5.12 Meditative absorption (*samādhi*) and *siddhis*

- FACT: Higher concentrations may yield extraordinary capacities or ***siddhis***.
- ANALYSIS: But Yoga warns that these are obstacles if appropriated by egoity or fascination.
- ANALYSIS: They belong to the side-effects of concentration, not to the essence of isolation (*kaivalya*).

5.13 Role of Lord (*Īśvara*) in meditative absorption (*samādhi*)

- FACT: **Dedication to the Lord (*Īśvara-praṇidhāna*)** is both a **observance (*niyama*)** and an independent means conducive to meditative absorption (*samādhi*).
- FACT: Devotion or surrender to Lord (*Īśvara*) stabilizes mind-field (*citta*) and helps overcome obstacles.
- FACT: Lord (*Īśvara*) is also linked to the meditative use of ***praṇava (OM)***.

- ANALYSIS: In Yoga, theism is practical: Lord (Īśvara) functions as an unsurpassed focus, model and aid to concentration.

5.14 Obstacles and their removal

- FACT: Classical Yoga lists obstacles (**antarāyas**) such as disease, mental dullness, doubt, carelessness, laziness, sensuality, false perception, failure to attain stages and instability in attained stages.
- FACT: Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) is one of the important means of overcoming these.
- ANALYSIS: This is why questions on meditative absorption (samādhi) often open into the role of God: Yoga's God is not a creator-first doctrine but a **practice-enabling doctrine**.

5.15 Meditative absorption (samādhi) in the 2022 PYQ

- FACT: The 2022 question required the **nature and stages of meditative absorption (samādhi)** along with the **role of Lord (Īśvara)**.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore a complete answer must cover the distinction between samprajñāta and asamprajñāta (including YS 1.18's *saṃskāra-śeṣa* and its further culmination in YS 1.51's *nirbīja*), the YS 1.17 fourfold characterisation, the samāpatti-bhedas, dharmamegha as culmination, and devotional concentration on Lord (Īśvara) as an aid.

5.16 Mini-conclusion on meditative absorption (samādhi)

- ANALYSIS: A sharp answer line: **meditative absorption (samādhi) is the progressive refinement of concentration from object-supported cognitive absorption (sabīja, YS 1.46) through non-cognitive absorption with residual impressions (asamprajñāta, YS 1.18: *saṃskāra-śeṣa*) to the restraint of even that residue (nirbīja, YS 1.51), with YS 1.17's samprajñāta factors, the samāpatti refinements, and Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) as a powerful aid but not a substitute for discriminative realization.**

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control
 ->
 5. MEDITATIVE ABSORPTION (samādhi)
 ->
 5.1 Statement
 ->
 5.2 Object-supported absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) - with object / with seed
 ->
 UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Plain-language visual - liberation removes confusion, not consciousness

practice + detachment
 |
 afflictions (kleśas) weaken, meditative absorption (samādhi) stabilizes
 |
 DISCRIMINATIVE INSIGHT (viveka-khyāti): Conscious witness (puruṣa) is not mind-field (citta)/Primordial material nature (prakṛti)
 |
 supreme detachment + dharmamegha
 |
 ISOLATION (kaivalya): Conscious witness (puruṣa) abides in its own nature

LORD (Īśvara) helps the path but does not replace discernment.

In simple words: Isolation (kaivalya) is isolation of consciousness from material nature, not union with God or Brahman. Lord (Īśvara) is a perfect, eternally free Conscious witness (puruṣa) who supports concentration, surrender and teaching.

Lord (Īśvara) is	Lord (Īśvara) is not
Purusa-visesa	Material cause

Lord (Īśvara) is	Lord (Īśvara) is not
Untouched by affliction (kleśa) and action and moral consequence (karma)	Ordinary karmic self
Timeless teacher	Nyaya-style creator by default
Privileged meditative support	External giver of isolation (kaivalya)

Memory line: God accelerates the path; viveka completes it.

6. ISOLATION (kaivalya)

6.1 Exact meaning

- FACT: **Isolation (kaivalya)** means aloneness, isolation or absolute distinctness.
- FACT: In Yoga it is the isolation of **conscious witness (puruṣa)** from **primordial material nature (prakṛti)** and its evolutes.
- FACT: It is therefore **not** union with God, **not** merger into Brahman, and **not** mere relief from pain considered negatively.
- ANALYSIS: The precise meaning must always be guarded because UPSC frequently tests it through contrasts.

6.2 Why isolation (kaivalya) is needed if conscious witness (puruṣa) is already pure

- FACT: Conscious witness (puruṣa) is indeed eternally pure, inactive and free.
- FACT: Yet through ignorance, mind-field (citta)'s modifications are appropriated as self.
- FACT: Isolation (kaivalya) is the cessation of this false relation at the level of experience and bondage.
- ANALYSIS: So liberation is not a production of a new essence; it is the ending of misidentification.

6.3 The process leading to isolation (kaivalya)

Sustained practice (abhyāsa) + Dispassion (vairāgya)
↓
Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) and Eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga)
↓
Attenuation and destruction of afflictions (kleśas)
↓
Stable meditative absorption (samādhi)
↓
Discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) (discriminative discernment)
↓
Para-vairāgya (supreme detachment)
↓
Cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi)
↓
Isolation (kaivalya)

6.4 Discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)

- FACT: **Discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)** is discriminative knowledge discerning the absolute difference between conscious witness (puruṣa) and primordial material nature (prakṛti).
- FACT: It is the decisive knowledge that ends confusion.
- ANALYSIS: Yoga thus remains deeply cognitivist at the summit: meditative absorption (samādhi) is indispensable, but its soteriological function is to mature discriminative discernment.

6.5 Para-vairāgya

- FACT: **Para-vairāgya** is supreme detachment even from the highest subtle attainments.
- FACT: The yogin ceases to crave powers, experiences, pleasures, even exalted cognitive states.
- ANALYSIS: Without this, subtle egoity can survive advanced practice.

6.6 Dharmamegha and final transition

- FACT: In **cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi)**, the cloud of dharma pours down the fullness of liberating discernment.
- FACT: The final barriers to isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa) are removed.

- ANALYSIS: This is not a divine grace replacing effort; it is the ripened summit of perfected discipline and discernment.

6.7 Reverse evolution (pratiprasava) of the qualities (guṇas)

- FACT: With liberation, the **qualities (guṇas)** cease to function for the liberated conscious witness (puruṣa) and resolve back toward their source.
- FACT: This return or involution is described as **reverse evolution (pratiprasava)** - reabsorption back into primordial material nature (prakṛti).
- FACT: Mind-field (citta), as a product of primordial material nature (prakṛti), no longer binds; its function is exhausted.
- ANALYSIS: The metaphor is one of reversal of the evolutionary process for soteriological purposes.

6.8 Isolation (kaivalya) transition: farmer, burnt seed and potter's wheel

- FACT: The Kaivalya-pāda uses the **kṣetrika** (ksetrika; farmer) image: the farmer does not push water into the field by force; he breaches the embankment, and water flows by its own nature.
- ANALYSIS: Exam use: yogic discipline removes obstructions; it does not manufacture conscious witness (puruṣa)'s freedom, because conscious witness (puruṣa) is already free and primordial material nature (prakṛti)'s processes complete themselves when obstacles are removed.
- FACT: The burnt seed (**dagdha-bīja**) image explains why destroyed afflictions (kleśas) cannot germinate into future bondage.
- ANALYSIS: The potter's wheel image explains residual embodiment: even after liberating knowledge removes the push of fresh action and moral consequence (karma), the already-moving psycho-physical complex may continue briefly until its momentum is exhausted.
- ANALYSIS: This allows a careful account of **jīvanmukti** (jivanmukti; liberation while living) language in Yoga: the conscious witness (puruṣa) is no longer bound, though bodily-citta processes may continue until their residual cause is spent.

6.9 Establishment in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā)

- FACT: Isolation (kaivalya) may also be expressed as the abiding of consciousness in its own nature - **establishment in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā)**.
- ANALYSIS: This continues the logic of the foundational sūtra: when vṛttis cease, the seer stands in itself.

6.10 How Yoga isolation (kaivalya) differs from Advaita liberation (mokṣa)

Yoga	Advaita Vedānta
many conscious witness (puruṣas)	one Brahman as ultimate reality
liberation = isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa) from primordial material nature (prakṛti)	liberation = realization of identity of enduring self (ātman) and Brahman
no Brahman-doctrine	Brahman central
no merger or non-dual identity	liberation (mokṣa) is non-dual realization

- ANALYSIS: Therefore isolation (kaivalya) is not identity but **disentanglement**.
- ANALYSIS: Cross-reference: Vedānta.

6.11 How Yoga isolation (kaivalya) differs from Nyāya release (apavarga)

Yoga isolation (kaivalya)	Nyāya release (apavarga)
positive isolation of pure consciousness in its own nature	often described as cessation of pain and bondage
rooted in puruṣa-prakṛti discrimination	rooted in true knowledge of categories and self
mind-field (citta) resolves, conscious witness (puruṣa) shines	self remains but liberation is characterized more negatively

- ANALYSIS: UPSC-safe line: **Nyāya emphasizes cessation of suffering; Yoga emphasizes the isolation and self-abidance of conscious witness (puruṣa)**.

- ANALYSIS: Cross-reference: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

6.12 Lord (Īśvara) and isolation (kaivalya)

- FACT: Lord (Īśvara) assists the aspirant but does **not grant** isolation (kaivalya) as an external gift.
- FACT: Liberation finally depends on the yogin's own **discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)**.
- FACT: Lord (Īśvara) is the perfect model, object of devotion and remover of obstacles.
- ANALYSIS: This is central to the 2025 demand on the nature of God and his role in isolation (kaivalya).

6.13 What isolation (kaivalya) is not

- ANALYSIS: Not **union with God** in the bhakti-school sense.
- ANALYSIS: Not **identity with Brahman** in the Advaitic sense.
- ANALYSIS: Not **annihilation of consciousness**.
- ANALYSIS: Not **mere painlessness** abstracted from the self's own luminosity.
- ANALYSIS: Not **destruction of mind as substance**; rather, cessation of its binding modifications and reabsorption of its function into primordial material nature (prakṛti).

6.14 Mini-conclusion on isolation (kaivalya)

- ANALYSIS: Best exam sentence: **isolation (kaivalya) is the isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa) from primordial material nature (prakṛti), reached through discriminative discernment matured in meditative absorption (samādhi), with qualities (guṇas) returning to quiescence and consciousness abiding in its own form.**

7. LORD (Īśvara) IN YOGA

7.1 Why a separate section is necessary

- FACT: Though the syllabus clause names mind-field (citta) through isolation (kaivalya), UPSC repeatedly asks the role of **God** in Yoga.
- FACT: Yoga's distinctiveness from Sāṃkhya cannot be fully explained without Lord (Īśvara).
- ANALYSIS: Hence any mature note on Yoga must include a separate theistic section.

7.2 Definition: puruṣa-viśeṣa

- FACT: Yoga defines **Lord (Īśvara)** as a **puruṣa-viśeṣa** - a special conscious witness (puruṣa).
- FACT: He is untouched by **affliction (kleśa)**, **action and moral consequence (karma)**, **vipāka** and **āśaya**.
- FACT: This is the standard doctrinal core of the Yoga-sūtra account.

7.3 Omniscience and timeless teacherhood

- FACT: In Lord (Īśvara) lies the unsurpassed seed of omniscience.
- FACT: He is the teacher of the ancients and is not limited by time.
- FACT: He is denoted by **praṇava (OM)**.
- ANALYSIS: These predicates make Lord (Īśvara) the ideal meditative and pedagogic principle in Yoga.

7.4 Lord (Īśvara) is not creator in the Nyāya sense

- FACT: Yoga does **not** primarily present Lord (Īśvara) as creator-God.
- FACT: **Primordial material nature (prakṛti)** remains the material basis of worldly evolution.
- FACT: Evolution proceeds through the puruṣa-prakṛti framework, not through divine creation ex nihilo.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore Yoga's God differs sharply from the Nyāya God as **nimitta-kāraṇa** or efficient cause of the world-order.

7.5 Lord (Īśvara) is not a Vaiṣṇava-style personal saviour

- FACT: Though devotion to Lord (Īśvara) is accepted, Yoga does not make him a saviour who arbitrarily grants liberation.
- FACT: The structure of liberation remains impersonal in one crucial sense: it depends on the yogin's own discriminative realization.
- ANALYSIS: This must be clearly said to avoid importing later devotional theologies into classical Yoga.

7.6 Positive role of Lord (Īśvara)

Role of Lord (Īśvara) in Yoga	Explanation
Object of meditation	one-pointed devotion stabilizes mind-field (citta)
Aid through Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)	surrender reduces egoity and attachment
Remover of obstacles	helps counter antarāyas in practice
Perfect model	exemplifies untouched, unsurpassed spiritual status
Teacher principle	anchor of timeless transmission and authority

7.7 Why Yoga is called theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya)

- FACT: Because it preserves the Sāṃkhyan dualistic ontology while adding Lord (Īśvara).
- FACT: Hence the expression **theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya)** - Sāṃkhya with God.
- ANALYSIS: This is not a small decorative addition; it changes the psychological and devotional resources of the path while leaving the basic metaphysical dualism intact.

7.8 Lord (Īśvara) and praṇava

- FACT: Meditation on **OM** as the designation of Lord (Īśvara) is a canonical Yogic practice.
- ANALYSIS: This links theology, language, sound and contemplative concentration in a single discipline.

7.9 Lord (Īśvara), meditative absorption (samādhi) and isolation (kaivalya) together

- FACT: Lord (Īśvara) aids meditative absorption (samādhi) by offering a privileged support for concentration.
- FACT: Through obstacle-removal and ego-surrender, the aspirant's path to discriminative knowledge is accelerated.
- FACT: But isolation (kaivalya) still follows from **discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)**, not divine fiat.
- ANALYSIS: Thus the most accurate exam formula is: **Lord (Īśvara) is instrumental, not constitutive, in liberation.**

7.10 The 2025 demand

- FACT: The 2025 question asked for the **nature of God and his role in isolation (kaivalya)**.
- ANALYSIS: A strong answer should therefore establish four points:
 1. Lord (Īśvara) is a **special conscious witness (puruṣa)**.
 2. He is untouched by kleśa-karma-vipāka-āśaya.
 3. He aids concentration, removes obstacles and is the object of praṇava-mediated devotion.
 4. He does not create the world in the Nyāya sense and does not bestow isolation (kaivalya) independently of discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti).

7.11 Mini-conclusion on Lord (Īśvara)

- ANALYSIS: In Yoga, God is best understood as **the supreme contemplative support within a Sāṃkhyan metaphysical frame.**

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

->

6. ISOLATION (kaivalya)

->

6.1 Exact meaning

->

6.2 Why isolation (kaivalya) is needed if conscious witness (puruṣa) is already pure

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UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

Plain-language visual - four major comparison axes

SAMKHYA -> same ontology, no Lord (Īśvara), less detailed praxis
 NYAYA -> self-substance and creator God
 ADVAITA -> one Brahman, liberation as identity
 BUDDHISM-> no permanent Conscious witness (puruṣa), process-based meditation
 YOGA -> plural witnesses, realist objects, disciplined isolation

In simple words: Yoga must be located through exact contrasts. It is not merely Samkhya plus a decorative God, not Advaitic union, not Buddhist no-self and not Nyaya creator-theism.

Memory line: compare self, God, causation, mind and liberation one axis at a time.

8. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

8.1 Yoga and Sāṃkhya

Issue	Sāṃkhya	Yoga
Metaphysical base	puruṣa-prakṛti dualism; 25 principles (tattvas)	same basic ontology
God	nirīśvara	seśvara - admits Lord (Īśvara)
Main stress	explanatory metaphysics, viveka-jñāna	practical psychology, meditative discipline, meditative absorption (samādhi)
Liberation	isolation (kaivalya) through discrimination	isolation (kaivalya) through discrimination matured by yoga-practice

- ANALYSIS: Yoga does not reject Sāṃkhya; it operationalizes it.

8.2 Yoga and Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika

Issue	Yoga	Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika
Internal organ	mind-field (citta) as broad mind-complex	atomic sensory mind (manas) plus self-substance
God	special conscious witness (puruṣa), aid to meditation	creator/efficient cause and moral governor
Liberation	isolation (kaivalya) as isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa)	release (apavarga) as cessation of suffering
Valid knowledge	3 means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)	4 means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)

8.3 Yoga and Vedānta

Issue	Yoga	Advaita Vedānta
Ultimate reality	many conscious witness (puruṣas) + primordial material nature (prakṛti)	non-dual Brahman
Bondage	confusion of conscious witness (puruṣa) with mind-field (citta)/primordial material nature (prakṛti)	ignorance (avidyā)/adhyāsa causing Brahman-self ignorance
Liberation	isolation	identity-realization
God	meditative aid, special conscious witness (puruṣa)	saguṇa Brahman at vyāvahārika level

8.4 Yoga and Buddhism

Issue	Yoga	Buddhism
Self	enduring conscious witness (puruṣa)	nairātmyavāda/no permanent self
Affliction	afflictions (kleśas) rooted in ignorance (avidyā)	affliction (kleśa)/tṛṣṇā/ignorance (avidyā) nexus
Meditation	meditative absorption (samādhi) aimed at puruṣa-prakṛti discrimination	meditation aimed at insight into impermanence, non-self, dependent origination
Liberation	isolation (kaivalya)	cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa)

8.5 Kaivalya-pāda realism against Vijñānavāda/Yogācāra

Statement. FACT: The Kaivalya-pāda contains a genuine realist polemic: Yoga is not a mind-only idealism but a Sāṃkhya-realist system in which objects, mind-field (citta) and conscious witness (puruṣa) are distinct.

Opponent's prima-facie position (pūrvapakṣa). ANALYSIS: **Vijñānavāda/Yogācāra** argues that what is taken as an external object can be explained as cognition-only; the object need not be admitted as independently real.

Established conclusion (siddhānta). FACT: Yoga's reply is Sāṃkhya-realism: objects are not reducible to a single cognition, mind-field (citta) is itself knowable, and conscious witness (puruṣa) is required as the witness of the mind.

Argument.

1. FACT: **Vastu-sāmya / ekacitta-tantra argument.** An object is not dependent on one mind; if it were **ekacitta-tantra** (ekacitta-tantra; dependent on a single mind), it would vanish when that mind ceased to cognise it. ANALYSIS: The persistence and common availability of objects support object-realism.
2. FACT: **Mind's knownness argument.** Mind-field (citta) is not self-illuminating (**na tat svābhāsam**, na tat svabhasam), because it is itself **dṛśya** (dṛśya; an object seen) for conscious witness (puruṣa). ANALYSIS: A purely mind-only theory struggles to terminate the regress of cognitions cognising cognitions.
3. FACT: **Against simultaneous self-cognition.** The mind cannot fully apprehend itself and its object in the same act as though it were both lamp and illuminated object. ANALYSIS: Yoga therefore distinguishes the object, the mental modification and the witnessing conscious witness (puruṣa).
4. FACT: **Upārāga argument.** An object is known when mind-field (citta) is **uparakta** (uparakta; coloured/affected) by it; whether the object is known or unknown depends on mind-field (citta)'s colouring, which implies that the object is not identical with the cognition itself.

Presupposition. FACT: The argument presupposes Yoga's three-term realism: object (**viśaya**), mental modification (**citta-vṛtti**) and witness (**puruṣa**) are analytically distinct.

Example. FACT: The sphaṭika crystal near a flower again helps: the crystal becomes coloured by the flower, but the flower is not created by the crystal's colouration; similarly, mind-field (citta) is coloured by an object that stands outside the cognition.

Objection. ANALYSIS: The Yogācāra can reply that shared karmic traces explain intersubjective object-appearance without positing external objects.

Reply. ANALYSIS: Yoga reconstructs the answer by insisting that shared appearance itself is better explained by a common object plus multiple cittas than by private cognitions alone; the residual force is that Yoga must still explain precisely how external objects colour an insentient but subtle mind-field (citta).

Exam payoff. ANALYSIS: This material shows that Yoga is not only a praxis manual; it defends a metaphysically committed realism against Buddhist idealism.

8.6 Yoga and philosophy of religion

- ANALYSIS: Yoga's Lord (Īśvara) is useful for cross-paper deployment with Notions of God and Religious Experience.
- ANALYSIS: It represents a distinctive Indian model of God as contemplative principle rather than creator-first metaphysical absolute.

9. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

9.1 Criticism: If conscious witness (puruṣa) is inactive and pure, how can it ever be bound?

- ANALYSIS: The objection is that an inactive witness cannot genuinely enter bondage.
- FACT: Yoga's reply parallels Sāṃkhya: bondage belongs not to conscious witness (puruṣa) intrinsically but to misidentification through reflection in mind-field (citta).
- ANALYSIS: Thus bondage is phenomenological and epistemic, not an actual alteration of conscious witness (puruṣa).

9.2 Criticism: If mind-field (citta) is insentient, how can cognition occur at all?

- ANALYSIS: The challenge targets the possibility of experience in an unconscious psychical instrument.
- FACT: Yoga replies that mind-field (citta) becomes luminous by reflecting conscious witness (puruṣa), just as a crystal appears lit by what is near it.
- ANALYSIS: The school thus explains cognition through a relation of reflected consciousness rather than by attributing intrinsic consciousness to matter.

9.3 Criticism: Why count valid cognition itself as a vṛtti if it helps liberation?

- ANALYSIS: If means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is true, why restrain it?
- FACT: Yoga replies that even true cognition is still a modification.
- FACT: It is useful in its **akliṣṭa** form as a ladder toward discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti).
- ANALYSIS: But what serves as means at one stage must also finally be transcended.

9.4 Criticism: Is objectless absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi) just unconsciousness or sleep?

- FACT: No.
- FACT: Sleep is itself one vṛtti, while objectless absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi) is cessation of vṛttis through discipline.
- ANALYSIS: The difference lies in both genesis and value: sleep is natural obscurity; meditative absorption (samādhi) is luminous restraint.

9.5 Criticism: Why add Lord (Īśvara) if Sāṃkhya ontology already explains liberation?

- ANALYSIS: This is the classic challenge from nirīśvara Sāṃkhya.
- FACT: Yoga's answer is pragmatic and soteriological: Lord (Īśvara) offers a unique focus of devotion, removes obstacles and supports meditative absorption (samādhi).
- ANALYSIS: The addition is justified by practical efficacy rather than by an overhaul of metaphysical fundamentals.

9.6 Criticism: If liberation depends on discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti), does God become redundant?

- FACT: Not redundant, but non-final.
- FACT: Lord (Īśvara) is a privileged aid, not the substitute for discernment.
- ANALYSIS: This balanced answer is exactly what UPSC expects.

9.7 Criticism: Is Yoga's liberation merely negative isolation?

- ANALYSIS: Some critics see isolation (kaivalya) as a stark separation lacking fullness.
- FACT: Yoga replies that the positive side of liberation is **establishment in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā)**
 - abiding in pure consciousness free from all alien admixture.
- ANALYSIS: Its positivity is not ecstatic union but unconfused self-abidance.

9.8 Criticism: Is meditation (dhyāna) sufficient without ethics?

- FACT: Yoga's answer is no.
- FACT: Without ethical restraint (yama) and observance (niyama), meditative power can coexist with affliction and egoity.
- ANALYSIS: This is why the system places ethics at the foundation of contemplative success.

10. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: **Isolation (kaivalya) ≠ Advaita liberation (mokṣa) ≠ Nyāya release (apavarga)**. Yoga's isolation (kaivalya) is isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa), not identity with Brahman and not merely cessation of pain.
2. ANALYSIS: **Yoga's Lord (Īśvara) is not a creator-God in the Nyāya sense**. Do not import nimitta-kāraṇa language uncritically.
3. ANALYSIS: **Mind-field (citta) is not identical with sensory mind (manas) alone**. It includes determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) and sensory mind (manas) functioning together.
4. ANALYSIS: **Samprajñāta and asamprajñāta must not be reversed, and asamprajñāta must not be flatly equated with nirbīja**. Samprajñāta still has object-support (*saḥjā*, YS 1.46); asamprajñāta (YS 1.18) is defined as *saṁskāra-śeṣa*, i.e. residual impressions may still remain; nirbīja (YS 1.51) is the further condition in which even that residual saṁskāra is restrained.
5. ANALYSIS: **Do not conflate YS 1.17 with YS 1.42-1.44**. Samprajñāta's four factors are vitarka, vicāra, ānanda and ego-identification (asmitā); savitarkā/nirvitarkā/savicārā/nirvicārā are samāpatti-bhedas.
6. ANALYSIS: **Kliṣṭa/akliṣṭa qualifies vṛttis, not afflictions (kleśas)**. Afflictions (kleśas) are inherently afflictive.
7. ANALYSIS: **Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha) does not mean violent destruction of mind**. It means cessation of modifications so the seer abides in itself.
8. ANALYSIS: **Clinging to life (abhiniveśa) is present even in the wise**. Do not reduce it to mere doctrinal ignorance.
9. ANALYSIS: **Sleep is a vṛtti, not liberation**. Nidrā is not meditative absorption (samādhi).
10. ANALYSIS: **Yoga shares Sāṁkhya's constitutive principle (tattva) framework**. Do not write as if Yoga has a wholly separate cosmology.
11. ANALYSIS: **Lord (Īśvara) helps but does not grant isolation (kaivalya) from outside**. Liberation finally follows discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti).

11. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

11.1 Keywords

- FACT: **mind-field (citta)** - mind-complex
- FACT: **cittavṛtti** - modification of mind-field (citta)
- FACT: **nirodha** - restraint/cessation
- FACT: **draṣṭṛ / draṣṭā** - the seer
- FACT: **svarūpe'vasthānam** - abiding in one's own nature
- FACT: **affliction (kleśa)** - affliction
- FACT: **ignorance (avidyā)** - root ignorance
- FACT: **ego-identification (asmitā)** - egoity
- FACT: **rāga-dveṣa** - attachment-aversion pair
- FACT: **clinging to life (abhiniveśa)** - clinging to life
- FACT: **sustained practice (abhyāsa)** - sustained practice
- FACT: **dispassion (vairāgya)** - detachment
- FACT: **preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga)** - tapas, svādhyāya, Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)
- FACT: **bahiraṅga / antaraṅga** - external/internal limbs
- FACT: **integrated concentration (saṁyama)** - concentration (dhāraṇā) + meditation (dhyāna) + meditative absorption (samādhi)
- FACT: **discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)** - discriminative discernment
- FACT: **cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi)** - cloud-of-dharma meditative absorption (samādhi)
- FACT: **reverse evolution (pratiprasava)** - involution of qualities (guṇas)
- FACT: **isolation (kaivalya)** - aloneness/isolation
- FACT: **puruṣa-viśeṣa** - special conscious witness (puruṣa), Lord (Īśvara)

11.2 Statement bank

1. FACT: "Yogaś-citta-vṛtti-nirodhaḥ." Yoga is the restraint of the modifications of mind-field (citta).
2. FACT: "Tadā draṣṭuḥ svarūpe'vasthānam." Then the seer abides in its own nature.
3. FACT: Lord (Īśvara) is a special conscious witness (puruṣa) untouched by affliction (kleśa), action and moral consequence (karma), vipāka and āśaya.
4. ANALYSIS: Mind-field (citta) is a reflective instrument: it borrows consciousness from conscious witness (puruṣa) and colour from objects.
5. ANALYSIS: Ignorance (avidyā) is not simple ignorance of facts but existential misapprehension of self and value.
6. ANALYSIS: Akliṣṭa vṛttis are therapeutic ladders; even they are ultimately transcended.
7. ANALYSIS: Isolation (kaivalya) is isolation, not union.
8. ANALYSIS: Yoga is Sāṃkhya made practical and theistic.

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018-2025 audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership is 7 of 112 parts; 2018 is the only year without an owned part, although Yoga appears secondarily in the Nyāya proof-of-God comparison.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The restored 2020 demand requires an exact distinction between samprajñāta and objectless absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi), including cognitive support, saṃskāra residue and relation to seedless absorption.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not equate asamprajñāta with sleep or automatically with final isolation (kaivalya); state the role of prior discipline and latent impressions.

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

->

8. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

->

8.1 Yoga and Sāṃkhya

->

8.2 Yoga and Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika

->

UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

Plain-language visual - critical evaluation sequence

DOCTRINE -> PRESUPPOSITION -> OBJECTION

-> YOGA REPLY -> RESIDUAL PRESSURE -> VERDICT

Example:

mind-field (citta) restraint -> mind-field (citta) is real and distinct from Conscious witness (puruṣa)

- > Buddhist stream objection
- > continuing substrate bears saṃskaras
- > stream theory still remains possible

In simple words: evaluation must expose what each doctrine assumes and whether Yoga's reply fully answers the named rival.

Memory line: the reply matters, but so does what survives the reply.

11A. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER

Doctrine	Presupposition it rests on	What collapses if the presupposition is denied
FACT: Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha)	FACT: Mind-field (citta) really takes forms, can be restrained, and is distinct from conscious witness (puruṣa).	ANALYSIS: Nirodha becomes mere mental quietism, not liberation.
FACT: Affliction (kleśa) theory	FACT: Ignorance (avidyā) and its derivatives causally colour cognition, action and rebirth.	ANALYSIS: Yoga loses its diagnosis of bondage and becomes moral advice only.
FACT: Reflection/ego-identification (asmitā)	FACT: Conscious witness (puruṣa) is inactive consciousness; mind-field (citta) is transparent but insentient.	ANALYSIS: Bondage of a pure conscious witness (puruṣa) becomes inexplicable.
FACT: Eight-limbed discipline (aṣṭāṅga-yoga)	FACT: Body, conduct, breath, senses and attention condition mind-field (citta)'s purity.	ANALYSIS: Meditative absorption (samādhi) becomes disconnected from ethics and discipline.
FACT: Meditative absorption (samādhi)	FACT: Attention can become progressively object-transparent and finally seedless.	ANALYSIS: Meditation reduces to trance or concentration without soteriological force.
FACT: Karma-vipāka	FACT: Actions leave subtle deposits rooted in afflictions (kleśas) and ripen across experience.	ANALYSIS: Yoga becomes therapeutic psychology rather than a theory of cycle of rebirth (saṃsāra) and release.
FACT: Lord (Īśvara)	FACT: A special conscious witness (puruṣa) untouched by kleśa-karma-vipāka-āśaya is possible and useful for practice.	ANALYSIS: Yoga collapses toward nirīśvara Sāṃkhya and loses its distinctive devotional aid.
FACT: Isolation (kaivalya)	FACT: Conscious witness (puruṣa) is ultimately distinct from primordial material nature (prakṛti), and primordial material nature (prakṛti) functions for conscious witness (puruṣa)'s experience and release.	ANALYSIS: Isolation becomes unintelligible; Advaitic identity or Buddhist no-self becomes more plausible.

11B. OPPONENT'S PRIMA-FACIE POSITION (pūrvapakṣa)-ESTABLISHED CONCLUSION (siddhānta) LEDGER

Objector	Objection	Yoga's reply	Residual force ANALYSIS:
FACT: Buddhist kṣaṇikavāda	ANALYSIS: No persisting mind-field (citta) is needed; a stream of momentary cognitions explains experience.	FACT: Yoga invokes mind-field (citta) as a continuing prakṛtic substrate bearing saṃskāras and undergoing real transformation (pariṇāma-vāda).	ANALYSIS: Momentariness can still explain continuity through causal series without a substance.
FACT: Yogācāra/Vijñānavāda	ANALYSIS: External objects are unnecessary; cognition-only explains appearance.	FACT: Kaivalya-pāda realism: objects are not dependent on a single mind, and mind-field (citta) is known by conscious witness (puruṣa).	ANALYSIS: Shared karmic appearance remains a sophisticated idealist counter.
FACT: Advaita Vedānta	ANALYSIS: Why many conscious witness (puruṣas), and why make Lord (Īśvara) only a special conscious witness (puruṣa) rather than the sole reality?	ANALYSIS: Yoga replies from experience-plurality, Sāṃkhyan realism and the practical need for discriminating each conscious witness (puruṣa) from primordial material nature (prakṛti).	ANALYSIS: Advaita presses the unity of consciousness more radically.
FACT: Nyāya	ANALYSIS: The self is a substance with adventitious consciousness; why call conscious witness (puruṣa) consciousness itself, and why desire cessation of all vṛttis?	ANALYSIS: Yoga replies that consciousness cannot be an accidental property of the true seer, and nirodha reveals rather than destroys awareness.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's commonsense realism about persons and cognition remains attractive.
FACT: Cārvāka	ANALYSIS: Conscious witness (puruṣa), action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth and isolation (kaivalya) are unverifiable beyond perception.	ANALYSIS: Yoga replies through disciplined yogi-pratyakṣa, pragmatic transformation and the inadequacy of material pleasure to end suffering.	ANALYSIS: Public verification remains difficult.
FACT: Mīmāṃsā	ANALYSIS: A non-creator Lord (Īśvara) is otiose; ritual action, not yoga, secures dharma.	ANALYSIS: Yoga replies that ritual cannot by itself remove ignorance (avidyā)/ego-identification (asmitā), while Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) directly stabilizes mind-field (citta).	ANALYSIS: The traditional Yoga proof of Lord (Īśvara)'s necessity is weaker than Nyāya's creator-God argument.

11C. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING

School	Number of means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)	Ontology of self	Status of God	Theory of causation
FACT: Yoga	FACT: 3: perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), āgama/verbal testimony (śabda)	FACT: many conscious witness (puruṣas), pure inactive consciousness	FACT: Lord (Īśvara) as puruṣa-viśeṣa	FACT: pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda)/real transformation (pariṇāmavāda) for primordial material nature (prakṛti)
FACT: Sāṃkhya	FACT: 3	FACT: many conscious witness (puruṣas)	FACT: classical nirīśvara tendency	FACT: pre-existence of the effect in the cause (satkāryavāda)/real transformation (pariṇāmavāda)
FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	FACT: 4	FACT: self as enduring substance with qualities	FACT: creator/efficient cause God in later Nyāya	FACT: new production (ārambhavāda)/non-existence of the effect before production (asatkāryavāda)
ANALYSIS: Buddhism	ANALYSIS: often 2 in epistemological schools: perception (pratyakṣa) and inference (anumāna)	FACT: no permanent self	FACT: no creator God	FACT: dependent origination, often with kṣaṇikavāda
ANALYSIS: Jainism	ANALYSIS: means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) grouped as direct/indirect with subdivisions	FACT: many individual self (jīvas)	FACT: no creator God; perfected siddhas	FACT: real substance with changing modes under anekāntavāda
ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā	CAUTION: sub-school variation, commonly 5 or 6	FACT: enduring self	FACT: creator God not necessary in classical ritualism	FACT: ritual action produces apūrva
FACT: Advaita Vedānta	FACT: commonly 6	FACT: one non-dual ātman-Brahman	FACT: Lord (Īśvara) as saguṇa Brahman at empirical level	FACT: vivartavāda at the highest level

School	Nature of liberation	Jīvanmukti?
FACT: Yoga	FACT: isolation (kaivalya), isolation of conscious witness (puruṣa)	ANALYSIS: qualified residual-embodiment language; final isolation when causes are exhausted
FACT: Sāṃkhya	FACT: isolation (kaivalya) through viveka	ANALYSIS: broadly compatible with liberated-while-living language
FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	FACT: release (apavarga) as cessation of suffering	ANALYSIS: not central; liberation usually after embodied bondage ceases
ANALYSIS: Buddhism	FACT: cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa)	FACT: nirvāṇa-with-remainder in some frameworks
ANALYSIS: Jainism	FACT: kevala-jñāna and final siddhahood	FACT: embodied kevalin before final release
ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā	FACT: cessation of bondage / attainment linked to dharma	ANALYSIS: not a central doctrine
FACT: Advaita Vedānta	FACT: liberation (mokṣa) as Brahman-realization	FACT: strongly admitted

Precise Sāṃkhya-Yoga difference. FACT: Yoga is not merely "Sāṃkhya plus God" in a decorative sense.

ANALYSIS: It retains Sāṃkhya's puruṣa-prakṛti ontology but adds (i) **Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)** as a practical means, (ii) a more elaborate psychology of restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha), (iii) samādhi-methodology and yogi-pratyakṣa, and (iv) a systematic path from kleśa-attenuation to isolation (kaivalya).

ANALYSIS: In a discuss-answer, say: **Sāṃkhya supplies the metaphysical grammar; Yoga turns it into a disciplined technology of liberation with Lord (Īśvara) as a privileged contemplative aid.**

11D. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON

Western parallel	Point of contact	Disanalogy / limit
ANALYSIS: Husserl's epoché/reduction vs nirodha	ANALYSIS: Both suspend the natural attitude toward ordinary experience.	ANALYSIS: Epoché is methodological and retains the constituting ego; nirodha is soteriological and aims at cessation of the mental stream's binding modifications.
ANALYSIS: Descartes' cogito vs conscious witness (puruṣa)	ANALYSIS: Both make consciousness indubitable.	ANALYSIS: The cogito yields a thinking substance that acts; conscious witness (puruṣa) is inactive, non-agentive witness-consciousness.
ANALYSIS: Kant's transcendental unity of apperception vs ego-identification (asmitā)	ANALYSIS: Both notice an "I think" accompanying representations.	ANALYSIS: Kant makes it a condition of objectivity; Yoga treats egoic I-am-appropriation as an affliction to be dissolved.
ANALYSIS: Spinoza's third kind of knowledge vs ṛtambharā	ANALYSIS: Both are non-discursive and higher than ordinary inference.	ANALYSIS: Spinoza's is knowledge of God/Nature under an attribute; Yoga's ṛtambharā is object-specific insight that must itself cease.
ANALYSIS: Aristotle's habituation vs abhyāsa-vairāgya	ANALYSIS: Both transform character through repeated discipline.	ANALYSIS: Aristotle aims at virtuous flourishing in the polis; Yoga aims at disentangling conscious witness (puruṣa) from primordial material nature (prakṛti).
ANALYSIS: Freud's unconscious vs saṃskāra/vāsanā	ANALYSIS: Both posit latent dispositions shaping conduct.	ANALYSIS: Saṃskāras are karmically indexed and metaphysically real deposits in a rebirth framework, not merely a psychodynamic hypothesis.

Rubric. ANALYSIS: Western parallels are illustrative garnish only; they never substitute for the Indian argument, and in an answer they must appear as at most one or two lines after the Yoga case is complete.

11E. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	What the examiner is testing	The structural move for a Yoga answer	How the closing verdict must be phrased
FACT: Explain	FACT: Accuracy of definition and canonical classification.	FACT: Define the term, give the list/stages, add a brief mechanism.	ANALYSIS: "Thus X functions as Y in Yoga's path to isolation (kaivalya)."
FACT: Discuss	FACT: Breadth plus significance.	FACT: Doctrine -> significance -> interpretive spread -> exam trap.	ANALYSIS: Balanced but affirmative: "Hence the doctrine is central, though not exhaustive."
FACT: Examine	FACT: Internal logic and assumptions.	FACT: State claim, unpack premises, show consequence for mind-field (citta)/affliction (kleśa)/meditative absorption (samādhi)/isolation (kaivalya).	ANALYSIS: "On its own presuppositions, the doctrine coherently explains..."
FACT: Critically examine	FACT: Objection-handling.	FACT: Doctrine -> named objection -> Yoga reply -> residual weakness.	ANALYSIS: Guarded verdict: "Strong as phenomenology/practice, weaker at metaphysical interaction."
FACT: Analyse	FACT: Causal structure.	FACT: Break into mechanism: ignorance (avidyā) -> ego-identification (asmitā) -> vṛtti/action and moral consequence (karma) -> vipāka -> nirodha.	ANALYSIS: "The doctrine is best read as a causal psychology of liberation."
FACT: Evaluate	FACT: Weighing strengths and weaknesses.	FACT: Give merits, limitations, and final graded assessment.	ANALYSIS: Use explicit grade: "philosophically strong in X, vulnerable in Y."
FACT: Compare	FACT: Similarities and differences across schools.	FACT: Use axes: self, God, causation, liberation, means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa).	ANALYSIS: End with precise uniqueness of Yoga, not a generic similarity.
FACT: Distinguish	FACT: Sharp conceptual separation.	FACT: Table of axes; define both sides; add one trap line.	ANALYSIS: "Therefore A must not be reduced to B."
FACT: Elucidate	FACT: Clarifying a dense statement.	FACT: Translate the statement, identify terms, illustrate with mind-field (citta)/reflection examples.	ANALYSIS: "The statement means..., not..."
FACT: Comment	FACT: Thesis-focused evaluation in brief.	FACT: One clear stand, two doctrinal supports, one qualification.	ANALYSIS: End with a crisp judgement, not a long summary.
FACT: Bring out	FACT: Making implicit implications explicit.	FACT: Extract presuppositions, consequences and exam relevance.	ANALYSIS: "This brings out Yoga's deeper claim that..."
FACT: Do you agree?	FACT: Ability to take a qualified position.	FACT: State agreement level, support with doctrine, concede limitation.	ANALYSIS: "I agree insofar as..., but not if it means..."

11F. GRADED VERDICT ON YOGA

Philosophically strong FACT:

- FACT: Yoga gives a rigorous phenomenology of mental process: vṛtti, smṛti, nidrā, saṃskāra, affliction (kleśa) and meditative absorption (samādhi) form a coherent psychology.
- FACT: It integrates psychology, ethics and metaphysics: yama-niyama, karma-vipāka and citta-nirodha are not separate compartments.
- FACT: It offers an operational path: sustained practice (abhyāsa), dispassion (vairāgya), preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga), aṣṭāṅga and meditative absorption (samādhi) supply a disciplined method rather than mere speculation.
- FACT: Its Kaivalya-pāda realist arguments show that Yoga is metaphysically committed, not merely a praxis manual.

Philosophically weak ANALYSIS:

- ANALYSIS: It inherits the puruṣa-prakṛti interaction problem: mere proximity explains much, but not all critics will accept it.
- ANALYSIS: Lord (Īśvara) has limited explanatory role: he aids practice but is not creator, material cause or final giver of isolation (kaivalya).
- ANALYSIS: The value of contentless pure consciousness can be questioned by schools that define fulfilment through knowledge, relation, bliss or activity.

Genuinely contested CAUTION:

- CAUTION: The precise commentarial status of ānanda/ego-identification (asmitā) as separate samāpattis or higher aspects of samprajñāta remains debated.
- CAUTION: Whether isolation (kaivalya) should be described as blissful self-abidance or as austere isolation is interpreted differently by expositors.
- CAUTION: The historical unity and layering of the Yogasūtra tradition remain scholarly questions; do not build a UPSC answer on uncertain dating claims.

Ready verdicts.

- ANALYSIS: **10 marks:** "Yoga is best read as a disciplined psychology of citta-nirodha grounded in Sāṃkhya dualism and completed in isolation (kaivalya)."
- ANALYSIS: **15 marks:** "Its strength lies in linking mental discipline, moral causation and liberation; its vulnerability lies in the unexplained proximity of inactive conscious witness (puruṣa) and active primordial material nature (prakṛti)."
- ANALYSIS: **20 marks:** "Yoga is philosophically richer than a praxis manual: it offers a realist metaphysics, a subtle moral psychology and a graded meditative epistemology, though its dualism and limited Lord (Īśvara) leave live objections for Advaita, Nyāya and Buddhist critics."

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

->

11A. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER

->

11B. OPPONENT'S PRIMA-FACIE POSITION (pūrvapakṣa)-ESTABLISHED CONCLUSION (siddhānta) LEDGER

->

11C. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING

->

UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

SESSION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

Plain-language visual - route the question first

QUESTION

|

- +-- mind-field (citta) levels
- +-- vṛttis and nirodha
- +-- afflictions (kleśas) and isolation (kaivalya)
- +-- meditative absorption (samādhi) distinctions
- +-- reflection and soteriology
- +-- Lord (Īśvara) and liberation

|

definition -> mechanism -> distinction -> evaluation

In simple words: the seven verified questions cover nearly the entire syllabus. Prepare reusable doctrinal blocks and adapt them to marks and directive rather than memorising disconnected essays.

Marks	Minimum architecture
10	Exact definition -> list/stages -> mechanism
15	Doctrine -> soteriological role -> distinction -> verdict

Marks	Minimum architecture
20	Full causal chain -> therapy -> comparison -> criticism

Memory line: every Yoga answer must return to the release of Conscious witness (puruṣa) from citta-identification.

12. PYQ ROUTING (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 7 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2019	Q7(b)	15 marks	How would Yoga philosophy comprehend the Citta-levels of a Scientist, a God-realized Devotee and a Self-realized Yogi? Justify your answer.
2020	Q5(b)	10 marks	Explain the difference between Object-supported absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) and Objectless absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi).
2021	Q6(a)	20 marks	Explain with reference to Yoga Philosophy, the nature of afflictions (kleśas). How does the removal of these lead to isolation (kaivalya)?
2022	Q5(c)	10 marks	Discuss the nature and different stages of Meditative absorption (samādhi) as per Pātañjala yoga and examine the role of Lord (Īśvara) in it.
2023	Q7(c)	15 marks	Explain Mind-field (citta) and its modifications in the philosophy of Yoga. Why does Yoga philosophy prescribe cessation of modifications of Mind-field (citta)? Give reasons in support of your answer.
2024	Q7(b)	15 marks	"So long as there are changes and modifications in mind-field (citta), the self is reflected therein, and, in the absence of discriminative knowledge, identifies itself with them." Present an appraisal of Yoga Soteriology in the light of the above statement.
2025	Q7(b)	15 marks	Explain the nature of God and its role in Isolation (kaivalya) in yoga philosophy.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

13. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

13.1 Ten-marker (10 marks)

Open with the exact doctrinal definition.
Name the canonical list/stages.
Give one causal or soteriological explanation.
Add one inter-school distinction or one trap-avoidance line.
Close by answering the directive directly.

Best use-cases: meditative absorption (samādhi) stages; citta-bhūmis; role of Lord (Īśvara); meaning of isolation (kaivalya).

13.2 Fifteen-marker (15 marks)

Frame the issue: Yoga as psychology of liberation within Sāṃkhya metaphysics.
Define the central term.
List and explain the canonical sub-types or stages.
Show why the doctrine matters for bondage/liberation.
Contrast with at least one rival school or one common confusion.
Conclude with one evaluative sentence.

Best use-cases: restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha); nature of God and role in isolation (kaivalya); mind-field (citta) and self-reflection.

13.3 Twenty-marker (20 marks)

Intro: locate Yoga as theistic Sāṃkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya).
Exposition: define and classify the demanded concept fully.
Mechanism: show the causal chain from ignorance/affliction (kleśa) to bondage.
Therapy: explain preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) / aṣṭāṅga / meditative absorption (samādhi) / discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) as needed.
Comparison: differentiate from Sāṃkhya, Advaita or Nyāya.
Critique and reply: add at least one live objection.
Conclusion: isolation (kaivalya) as the school's final soteriological meaning.

Best use-case: afflictions (kleśas) and their removal leading to isolation (kaivalya).

13.4 Directive-word cues for Yoga answers

- ANALYSIS: The expanded directive decoder is now consolidated in §11E. **DIRECTIVE DECODER** immediately before the PYQ routing section.
- FACT: The original cues are preserved there and expanded into directive-specific structure, examiner demand and closing-verdict formulae.

14. LINK-OUTS

- Metaphysical base: Samkhya.md
- Comparative Vedānta contrasts: Vedanta.md
- Realist contrast on self, God and liberation: Nyaya-Vaisesika.md
- Cross-school self/liberation matrix: Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md
- Cross-school epistemology and Yoga's 3 means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas): Pramana-across-schools.md
- Cross-paper God concepts: Notions-of-God.md
- Cross-paper mystical cognition / meditative absorption (samādhi) parallels: Religious-Experience.md
- Paper I house constitution: ../00_Master-Framework.md
- PYQ bank: ../PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md

SOURCES

- Patañjali, *Yoga-sūtra*.
- Vyāsa, *Yoga-bhāṣya*.
- Vācaspati Miśra, *Tattvavaiśārādī*.
- Vijñānabhikṣu, *Yogavārttika*.
- S. Chatterjee and D. Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. II.

CURRENT LINKAGE - PUBLIC YOGA AND PHILOSOPHICAL YOGA

FACT: Official contemporary anchor: The Ministry of AYUSH's Yoga Mahotsav on **13 March 2026** began the countdown to International Day of Yoga and emphasized public-health protocols, daily practice and broad participation. This is useful as a contemporary opening, but it primarily concerns wellness promotion.

FACT: Updated official anchor, 21 June 2026: The 12th International Day of Yoga used the theme **Yoga for Healthy Ageing**, with the Ministry of Ayush as the nodal ministry. The theme supports a contemporary preventive-health opening, while remaining distinct from Patanjali's metaphysical and soteriological claims.

ANALYSIS: Doctrine boundary: Patanjala Yoga is not reducible to exercise or disease-management protocols. Its philosophical core is restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha), removal of afflictions (kleśas), meditative absorption (samādhi), discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) and isolation (kaivalya). Public-wellness initiatives illustrate social relevance; they do not establish metaphysical claims about Conscious witness (puruṣa), Primordial material nature (prakṛti) or Lord (Īśvara).

Direct local source anchors

- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 233-245: mind-field (citta), five vṛttis, citta-bhumis, meditative absorption (samādhi), eight limbs and God.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 167-172: Patanjala definition, reflection, eight limbs and Lord (Īśvara).
- FACT: The repository PYQ bank controls wording and marks for the seven solved questions.

SUBTOPIC CLOSURE FLOW

PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

->

12. PYQ ROUTING (2018-2025)

->

13. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

->

13.1 Ten-marker (10 marks)

->

UPSC distinction and qualified verdict

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

Rapid recall

- Yoga shares Samkhya's 25 principles (tattvas) and dualism.
- Mind-field (citta) is material-subtle; Conscious witness (puruṣa) is conscious.
- Reflection explains empirical cognition and misidentification.
- Yoga-fit states: one-pointed mind (ekāgra) and fully restrained mind (niruddha).
- Trap: high intellectual concentration alone is not final yogic restraint.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind

Rapid recall

- Yoga = restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha).
- Then the seer abides in its own nature.
- Five vṛttis; each may be klista or aklista.
- Means: sustained practice (abhyāsa) and dispassion (vairāgya).
- Trap: nirodha is not destruction of consciousness.

RAPID REVISION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

Rapid recall

- Root affliction (kleśa): ignorance (avidyā).
- Ego-identification (asmitā) confuses seer and instrument.
- Attachment (rāga) follows pleasure; aversion (dveṣa) follows pain; clinging to life (abhiniveśa) clings to life.
- Eight limbs move from ethics to absorption.
- Integrated concentration (saṃyama) = concentration (dhāraṇā) + meditation (dhyāna) + meditative absorption (samādhi).

RAPID REVISION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control

Rapid recall

- Samprajñata: object-supported and cognitive.
- Asamprajñata: cessation with possible residual impression.
- Nirbija: even residual seed ceases.
- Rāmbhara prajna follows mature nirvicara.
- Trap: samapatti subtypes are not YS 1.17's four factors.

RAPID REVISION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Rapid recall

- Isolation (kaivalya) = isolation/self-establishment of Conscious witness (puruṣa).
- Path culminates in discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) and supreme detachment.
- Lord (Īśvara) is special Conscious witness (puruṣa), pranava's referent and timeless teacher.
- Lord (Īśvara) is instrumental, not constitutive, in liberation.
- Trap: Yoga is Sesvara, but not creator-theism in the straightforward Nyaya sense.

RAPID REVISION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

Rapid recall

- Samkhya supplies metaphysics; Yoga adds praxis and Lord (Īśvara).
- Yoga defends external objects against mind-only theory.
- Strongest area: integrated ethics and psychology.
- Weakest area: Purusa-Prakriti interaction and limited divine necessity.
- Trap: public wellness Yoga is not the whole Patanjala system.

RAPID REVISION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

Rapid recall

- Strengths: phenomenology, ethical psychology, practical sequence, meditative analysis.
- Weaknesses: interaction, limited Lord (Īśvara) role, verification of extraordinary claims.
- Best verdict: philosophically richer than exercise, strongest as a disciplined psychology of liberation.

RAPID REVISION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

Rapid recall - master route

Prompt	Recall spine
Mind-field (citta)	material mind-complex reflecting Conscious witness (puruṣa)
Vṛtti	five forms; restraint through practice and detachment
Affliction (kleśa)	avidya-rooted causal colouring
Path	preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) and eight limbs
Meditative absorption (samādhi)	supported, beyond objectification, seedless
Lord (Īśvara)	special Conscious witness (puruṣa) and contemplative aid
Isolation (kaivalya)	discrimination, involution and self-abidance

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Yoga is defined as: A. restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha) B. union with creator C. bodily fitness D. ritual action	A	Patanjali defines Yoga as restraint of mental modifications.
2	Mind-field (citta) includes: A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) alone B. determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) and sensory mind (manas) C. gross body only D. five elements	B	It is the operative inner instrument.
3	The scientist in the PYQ is best placed at: A. dull mind (mūḍha) B. restless mind (kṣipta) C. distracted mind (vikṣipta) D. fully restrained mind (niruddha)	C	Strong but outward and intermittent focus remains distracted mind (vikṣipta).

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
4	Complete restraint corresponds to: A. one-pointed mind (ekāgra) B. dull mind (mūḍha) C. distracted mind (vikṣipta) D. fully restrained mind (niruddha)	D	Fully restrained mind (niruddha) is fully restrained mind-field (citta).
5	Root affliction (kleśa) is: A. ignorance (avidyā) B. attachment (rāga) C. aversion (dveṣa) D. clinging to life (abhiniveśa)	A	Other afflictions grow in ignorance (avidyā)'s field.
6	Confusion of seer and seeing instrument is: A. smṛti B. ego-identification (asmitā) C. nidra D. means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	B	Ego-identification (asmitā) identifies Conscious witness (puruṣa) with determinative intellect (buddhi)/mind-field (citta).
7	Attachment based on pleasure is: A. clinging to life (abhiniveśa) B. ignorance (avidyā) C. attachment (rāga) D. aversion (dveṣa)	C	Attachment (rāga) follows remembered pleasure.
8	Instinctive clinging to life is: A. ego-identification (asmitā) B. attachment (rāga) C. aversion (dveṣa) D. clinging to life (abhiniveśa)	D	It persists even in the learned.
9	Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) consists of: A. tapas, svadhyaya, Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna) B. ethical restraint (yama), observance (niyama), posture (āsana) C. concentration (dhāraṇā), meditation (dhyāna), meditative absorption (samādhi) D. means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), viparyaya, smṛti	A	These attenuate afflictions (kleśas) and prepare meditative absorption (samādhi).
10	The fifth limb is: A. breath regulation (prāṇāyāma) B. sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra) C. concentration (dhāraṇā) D. meditation (dhyāna)	B	Withdrawal follows breath regulation.
11	Continuous flow of attention is: A. posture (āsana) B. concentration (dhāraṇā) C. meditation (dhyāna) D. integrated concentration (saṃyama)	C	Meditation (dhyāna) is uninterrupted meditative flow.
12	Combined dharana-dhyana-samadhi is: A. nirodha B. viveka C. preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) D. integrated concentration (saṃyama)	D	Integrated concentration (saṃyama) is their integrated application.
13	Valid cognition is called: A. pramana-vṛtti B. viparyaya C. vikalpa D. nidra	A	Even truth is a modification of mind-field (citta).
14	Word-based construction without object is: A. smṛti B. vikalpa C. means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) D. meditative absorption (samādhi)	B	Vikalpa arises from words lacking corresponding fact.
15	Sleep counts as vṛtti because: A. it is meditative absorption (samādhi) B. Conscious witness (puruṣa) sleeps C. absence-cognition leaves a recollectable impression D. all senses act	C	Later recollection indicates a supporting mental mode.
16	Samprajnata meditative absorption (samādhi) retains: A. no samskara whatsoever B. creator-consciousness C. bodily motion D. cognitive object/support	D	It is absorption with prajna and seed.
17	Truth-bearing insight is: A. rambhara prajna B. ego-identification (asmitā) C. viveka only after death D. savitarka	A	It arises from mature nirvicara.
18	Lord (īśvara) is: A. Primordial material nature (prakṛti) B. purusa-visesa C. material creator D. liberated mind-field (citta)	B	He is eternally untouched special Conscious witness (puruṣa).
19	Lord (īśvara)'s verbal symbol is: A. Veda B. mahat C. pranava D. akasa	C	Om/pranava is contemplated with its meaning.
20	Isolation (kaivalya) means: A. union with Brahman B. heavenly enjoyment C. merging into God D. isolation and self-establishment of Conscious witness (puruṣa)	D	It is separation from guna-purpose.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
21	Immediate liberating cognition is: A. discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) B. sensory perception C. testimony alone D. memory	A	Stable discrimination separates seer and seen.
22	Dharmamegha meditative absorption (samādhi) is linked with: A. attachment to powers B. supreme dispassion and final removal of affliction C. ordinary concentration D. sleep	B	It culminates the path when insight itself is not appropriated.
23	Yoga differs from Samkhya chiefly by: A. rejecting Conscious witness (puruṣa) B. denying Primordial material nature (prakṛti) C. adding disciplined praxis and Lord (Īśvara) D. accepting monism	C	It is often called theistic Samkhya (śeṣvara-sāṃkhya).
24	Best doctrinal warning: A. Yoga is exercise only B. isolation (kaivalya) is union C. Lord (Īśvara) creates matter D. public wellness Yoga must not replace Patanjala soteriology	D	Contemporary practice and classical doctrine must be distinguished.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	One-pointed mind (ekāgra) means: A. one-pointed mind-field (citta) B. torpid mind-field (citta) C. fully seedless state D. error	A	It is Yoga-fit concentration but not complete restraint.
26	Which vṛtti is recollection? A. nidra B. smṛti C. vikalpa D. viparyaya	B	Smṛti retains past experience.
27	Afflictions (kleśas) in attenuated condition are: A. prasupta B. udara C. tanu D. vicchinna	C	Tanu means thinned through practice.
28	Asamprajnata is not sleep because it: A. contains ordinary dreams B. is caused by fatigue C. lacks discipline D. results from nirodha and transformative saṃskara	D	Its causal and soteriological structure differs from nidra.
29	First five limbs are generally: A. bahiranga B. antaranga C. integrated concentration (saṃyama) D. isolation (kaivalya)	A	They are external aids relative to the final three.
30	Yoga's Lord (Īśvara) primarily functions as: A. material cause B. aid to concentration and timeless teacher C. karmic sufferer D. universal substance	B	Patanjali's emphasis is practical.
31	Reflection theory says: A. Conscious witness (puruṣa) changes into mind-field (citta) B. mind-field (citta) is self-luminous C. mind-field (citta) appears conscious through Conscious witness (puruṣa)'s reflection D. both are identical	C	Mind-field (citta) borrows luminosity without changing Conscious witness (puruṣa).
32	Best overall verdict: A. Yoga is posture science B. meditative absorption (samādhi) alone automatically liberates C. God replaces discrimination D. Yoga integrates ethics and psychology, though dualist interaction remains contested	D	This captures its strength and central pressure.

ADVANCED CLOSE-DISTINCTION MCQS - 16 QUESTIONS

Supplemental MCQ 1

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. Cessation of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha) stills misidentification; it does not destroy mind-stuff. B. It annihilates the conscious witness (puruṣa). C. It makes every cognition false by definition. D. It is identical with dreamless sleep.

Answer: A. Cessation of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha) stills misidentification; it does not destroy mind-stuff.

Explanation: Yoga distinguishes disciplined cessation from unconscious latency or destruction.

Supplemental MCQ 2 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. Cessation of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha) stills misidentification; it does not destroy mind-stuff.
2. It annihilates the conscious witness (puruṣa).

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. 1 only C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: B. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. Yoga distinguishes disciplined cessation from unconscious latency or destruction.

Supplemental MCQ 3

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. They are the five restraints (yamas). B. They are the five gross elements. C. The five afflictions (kleśas) are ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life. D. They are five valid cognitions.

Answer: C. The five afflictions (kleśas) are ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life.

Explanation: Yoga Sūtra II.3 gives this causal-afflictive set.

Supplemental MCQ 4 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. The five afflictions (kleśas) are ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life.
2. They are the five restraints (yamas).

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. Both 1 and 2 C. Neither 1 nor 2 D. 1 only

Answer: D. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. Yoga Sūtra II.3 gives this causal-afflictive set.

Supplemental MCQ 5

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. Cognitive absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) retains an object-support; non-cognitive absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi) leaves only latent impressions. B. Both are merely ethical restraints. C. The second necessarily means liberation has already occurred. D. The first is ordinary distraction.

Answer: A. Cognitive absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) retains an object-support; non-cognitive absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi) leaves only latent impressions.

Explanation: The distinction concerns object-supported cognition and residual seed, not two kinds of sleep.

Supplemental MCQ 6 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. Cognitive absorption (samprajñāta-samādhi) retains an object-support; non-cognitive absorption (asamprajñāta-samādhi) leaves only latent impressions.
2. Both are merely ethical restraints.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. 1 only C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: B. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. The distinction concerns object-supported cognition and residual seed, not two kinds of sleep.

Supplemental MCQ 7

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. Lord is the material cause that evolves into the world. B. Lord is the collective mind-field (citta). C. Lord (Īśvara) is a special conscious witness (puruṣa-viśeṣa), untouched by affliction, action, fruition and latent deposit. D. Lord replaces discriminative knowledge as the definition of isolation.

Answer: C. Lord (Īśvara) is a special conscious witness (puruṣa-viśeṣa), untouched by affliction, action, fruition and latent deposit.

Explanation: Pātañjala Yoga assigns a special practical and exemplary role without adopting Nyāya's creator proof.

Supplemental MCQ 8 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. Lord (Īśvara) is a special conscious witness (puruṣa-viśeṣa), untouched by affliction, action, fruition and latent deposit.
2. Lord is the material cause that evolves into the world.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. Both 1 and 2 C. Neither 1 nor 2 D. 1 only

Answer: D. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. Pātañjala Yoga assigns a special practical and exemplary role without adopting Nyāya's creator proof.

Supplemental MCQ 9

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. The eight limbs move from ethical restraint and observance through posture, breath and withdrawal to concentration, meditation and absorption. B. They begin with absorption and end with social ethics. C. They exclude bodily and respiratory disciplines. D. They are eight metaphysical categories rather than practices.

Answer: A. The eight limbs move from ethical restraint and observance through posture, breath and withdrawal to concentration, meditation and absorption.

Explanation: The sequence integrates outer discipline, inner discipline and meditative culmination.

Supplemental MCQ 10 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. The eight limbs move from ethical restraint and observance through posture, breath and withdrawal to concentration, meditation and absorption.
2. They begin with absorption and end with social ethics.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. 1 only C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: B. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. The sequence integrates outer discipline, inner discipline and meditative culmination.

Supplemental MCQ 11

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. Yoga rejects conscious witness (puruṣa). B. Yoga accepts only one universal conscious witness. C. Yoga largely accepts Sāṃkhya metaphysics but adds a distinctive Lord doctrine and a detailed discipline of mind. D. Yoga identifies liberation with merging into primordial material nature (prakṛti).

Answer: C. Yoga largely accepts Sāṃkhya metaphysics but adds a distinctive Lord doctrine and a detailed discipline of mind.

Explanation: The relationship is close but not identity.

Supplemental MCQ 12 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. Yoga largely accepts Sāṃkhya metaphysics but adds a distinctive Lord doctrine and a detailed discipline of mind.
2. Yoga rejects conscious witness (puruṣa).

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. Both 1 and 2 C. Neither 1 nor 2 D. 1 only

Answer: D. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. The relationship is close but not identity.

Supplemental MCQ 13

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. Isolation (kaivalya) is the disentanglement of conscious witness from the qualities (guṇas) through discriminative knowledge. B. It is the production of a new eternal self. C. It is bodily immortality. D. It is union of conscious witness with primordial material nature.

Answer: A. Isolation (kaivalya) is the disentanglement of conscious witness from the qualities (guṇas) through discriminative knowledge.

Explanation: Yoga liberation ends false identification rather than creating consciousness.

Supplemental MCQ 14 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. Isolation (kaivalya) is the disentanglement of conscious witness from the qualities (guṇas) through discriminative knowledge.
2. It is the production of a new eternal self.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. 1 only C. Both 1 and 2 D. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: B. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. Yoga liberation ends false identification rather than creating consciousness.

Supplemental MCQ 15

Which one of the following is the most accurate statement?

A. They are identical with the five afflictions. B. Only painful thoughts count as modifications. C. The five mental modifications include valid cognition, error, conceptual construction, sleep and memory. D. Memory is excluded because it concerns the past.

Answer: C. The five mental modifications include valid cognition, error, conceptual construction, sleep and memory.

Explanation: The fivefold classification is independent of whether a modification is afflicted or unafflicted.

Supplemental MCQ 16 - statement combination

Consider the following statements:

1. The five mental modifications include valid cognition, error, conceptual construction, sleep and memory.
2. They are identical with the five afflictions.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

A. 2 only B. Both 1 and 2 C. Neither 1 nor 2 D. 1 only

Answer: D. 1 only

Explanation: Statement 1 is correct; statement 2 confuses a nearby doctrine. The fivefold classification is independent of whether a modification is afflicted or unafflicted.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

Exam route

- **2019 Q7(b):** classify scientist as distracted mind (vikṣipta), God-centred devotee as one-pointed mind (ekāgra) and self-realized yogi as fully restrained mind (niruddha), with justification.
- Define mind-field (citta) as buddhi-ahamkara-manas functioning together.
- State that mind-field (citta) is not self-luminous and Conscious witness (puruṣa) does not literally change.
- Open broad answers with Yoga as **Theistic Samkhya (seśvara-sāṃkhya) plus disciplined soteriology**.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind

Exam route

- **2023 Q7(c):** define mind-field (citta), list five vṛttis and derive why nirodha is necessary.
- **2024 Q7(b):** connect changing mind-field (citta), reflected consciousness, absent discrimination and Yoga's whole soteriology.
- Explain why means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) may be aklista yet remains a vṛtti.
- Distinguish nidra from disciplined cessation and asamprajnata meditative absorption (samādhi).

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

Exam route

- **2021 Q6(a):** define all five afflictions (kleśas), their four states and the chain from affliction to action and moral consequence (karma), then show how removal leads to isolation (kaivalya).
- Explain preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) as tapas, svadhyaya and Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna).
- Present eight limbs functionally: what disturbance each level treats.
- Never reduce posture (āśana) to the whole of Yoga or treat ethics as optional preparation.

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control

Exam route

- **2020 Q5(b):** distinguish samprajnata and asamprajnata by support, cognition, saṃskara and function.
- **2022 Q5(c):** present the stages accurately and integrate Lord (īśvara)'s instrumental role.
- State the two classification grids separately before showing commentarial reconciliation.
- Add the trap: asamprajnata is not automatically identical with nirbija.

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Exam route

- **2025 Q7(b):** define Lord (īśvara) precisely, explain positive functions and state why isolation (kaivalya) still depends on discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti).
- Distinguish Yoga isolation (kaivalya) from Advaita identity and Nyaya's cessation-centred release (apavarga).
- Explain reverse evolution (pratiprasava) and establishment in one's own nature (svarūpa-pratiṣṭhā).
- Never write that liberation is union with Lord (īśvara).

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

Exam route

Use a dialectic grid: **opponent -> target -> Yoga reply -> residual force.**

High-risk checks:

1. Mind-field (citta) is not sensory mind (manas) alone.
2. Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) can be true and still be a vṛtti.
3. Nidra is not meditative absorption (samādhi).
4. Klista/aklista qualifies vṛttis, not afflictions (kleśas).
5. Lord (Īśvara) assists but does not bestow isolation (kaivalya) externally.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

Exam route

- "Analyse" requires the causal chain from ignorance (avidyā) to action and moral consequence (karma) and release.
- "Critically examine" requires named objection, Yoga reply and remaining weakness.
- "Compare" should use means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), self, God, causation and liberation.
- Best overall criterion: operational explanatory power versus metaphysical verification and dualist interaction.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

Exam route

The complete practice section contains:

- **7 verified solved PYQs** from 2019-2025.
- **24 integrated MCQs** and **8 remedial MCQs**.
- Original 10-, 15- and 20-mark questions with model solutions.
- Final consolidated register notes after all teaching and practice.

Use current public-health Yoga only as a labelled contemporary anchor, never as doctrinal evidence.

Workbook Use Guide

Attempt each verified PYQ before reading its model solution. Then complete the integrated MCQs, remedial MCQs and original Mains practice. Correct MCQ options rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How would Yoga comprehend the citta-levels of a scientist, a God-realized devotee and a self-realized yogi?

Model solution

Yoga classifies mind-field (citta) into five bhumis: **restless mind (kṣipta)** (restless), **dull mind (mūḍha)** (dull), **distracted mind (vikṣipta)** (intermittently focused), **one-pointed mind (ekāgra)** (one-pointed), and **fully restrained mind (niruddha)** (fully restrained).

Person	Citta-level	Justification
Scientist	distracted mind (vikṣipta)	capable of sustained empirical focus, but attention remains outward and fluctuates beyond the chosen task
God-realized devotee	one-pointed mind (ekāgra)	mind is one-pointedly established in Lord (Īśvara) and fit for deep meditation
Self-realized yogi	fully restrained mind (niruddha)	all vṛttis are restrained and the seer abides in its own nature

The scientist should not automatically be called one-pointed mind (ekāgra) merely because of intellectual concentration. Yogic one-pointedness includes freedom from ordinary attachment and a stable inward orientation. The devotee's concentration is supported by Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna). The self-realized yogi has crossed from concentration on an object to complete restraint.

Verdict: The hierarchy measures not intelligence but the degree of guna-purification and freedom from mental dispersion.

Why this earns marks: It applies all three cases precisely, avoids equating technical focus with yogic realization, and explains the governing criterion.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Distinguish Samprajnata Meditative absorption (samādhi) and Asamprajnata Meditative absorption (samādhi).

Model solution

Samprajnata	Asamprajnata
cognitive absorption with an object	cessation beyond objectifying cognition
supported by prajna and a seed	only residual samskaras may remain
includes vitarka, vicara, ananda and ego-identification (asmitā) dimensions	reached through supreme dispassion and nirodha
yields truth-bearing insight at higher levels	prepares for nirbija when even seed is exhausted

Samprajnata is not ordinary thought. Mind-field (citta) becomes transparent and takes the object's form with extraordinary clarity. Its detailed samapatti distinctions-savitarka/nirvitarka and savicara/nirvicara-must not be confused mechanically with the fourfold Yoga Sutra 1.17 scheme.

Asamprajnata is not sleep or unconsciousness. Sleep is itself a vrtti supported by absence-cognition, whereas asamprajnata results from disciplined restraint and leaves a transformative nirodha-samskara.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes object, seed, cognition and residual impressions and directly removes the common sleep-confusion.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain the nature of afflictions (kleśas) and how their removal leads to isolation (kaivalya).

Model solution

Afflictions (kleśas) are afflictive structures colouring cognition and generating action and moral consequence (karma). The five are:

1. **Ignorance (avidyā):** mistaking impermanent for permanent, impure for pure, painful for pleasurable and not-self for self.
2. **Ego-identification (asmitā):** identification of seer with the seeing instrument.
3. **Attachment (rāga):** attachment based on remembered pleasure.
4. **Aversion (dveṣa):** aversion based on remembered pain.
5. **Clinging to life (abhiniveśa):** deep clinging to life, present even in the learned.

Ignorance (avidyā) is the field of the other four. Afflictions (kleśas) may be prasupta, tanu, vicchinna or udara-dormant, attenuated, interrupted or fully active.

ignorance (avidyā) → ego-identification (asmitā) → attachment (rāga)/aversion (dveṣa) → action
→ karmasaya → vipaka → rebirth and suffering

Their removal is graded. **Preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga)**-tapas, svadhyaya and Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)-attenuates them. Eight-limbed discipline purifies conduct, body, breath, senses and attention. Meditation (dhyāna) burns subtle afflictions; discriminative knowledge destroys ignorance (avidyā)'s root. When afflictions (kleśas) cease, fresh karmic deposits stop, old seeds are exhausted or burnt, and mind-field (citta) no longer produces identification.

Meditative absorption (samādhi) alone is instrumental unless it matures into **discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)**, uninterrupted discrimination between Conscious witness (puruṣa) and mind-field (citta). Para-vairagya prevents attachment even to insight and powers. Cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhi) completes the cessation of binding tendencies; the qualities (guṇas) undergo reverse evolution (pratiprasava) and Conscious witness (puruṣa) stands in isolation (kaivalya).

An objection says Conscious witness (puruṣa) was always free, so removal is unnecessary. Yoga replies that liberation removes misidentification in mind-field (citta), not an actual impurity in Conscious witness (puruṣa).

Verdict: Klesa-removal leads to isolation (kaivalya) by breaking both the cognitive root and karmic reproduction of bondage.

Why this earns marks: It defines all five, gives their states and causal chain, integrates preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga), astanga, meditative absorption (samādhi) and viveka, and answers the already-free objection.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim → named evidence → analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Discuss stages of Meditative absorption (samādhi) and examine the role of Lord (Īśvara).

Model solution

Patanjala Yoga broadly distinguishes **samprajnata** and **asamprajnata** meditative absorption (samādhi). Samprajnata retains cognitive support and is associated with vitarka, vicara, ananda and ego-identification (asmitā). The samapatti analysis further distinguishes gross and subtle absorptions with and without conceptual admixture. Nirvicara maturity yields **rtambhara prajna**, truth-bearing insight.

Asamprajnata suspends objectifying cognition while residual samskaras may remain. **Nirbija meditative absorption (samādhi)** occurs when even the seed sustaining further mental emergence is exhausted. Dharmamegha marks the culminating cloud of virtue and complete dispassion.

Lord (Īśvara) is **purusa-visesa**, eternally untouched by affliction (kleśa), action and moral consequence (karma), fruition and latent deposits. Devotion to Lord (Īśvara), repetition and contemplation of pranava, and surrender reduce obstacles and accelerate meditative absorption (samādhi).

Verdict: Lord (Īśvara) is a privileged practical aid and timeless teacher, not the material cause or automatic giver of isolation (kaivalya); discriminative knowledge remains decisive.

Why this earns marks: It gives the stage architecture without conflating lists and evaluates Lord (Īśvara)'s exact, limited function.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain mind-field (citta) and its modifications. Why prescribe cessation of cittavrttis?

Model solution

Mind-field (citta) is the material-subtle internal instrument comprising determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) and sensory mind (manas). It reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa) and assumes forms corresponding to objects. Its five vrttis are:

Vrtti	Meaning
Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	valid cognition
Viparyaya	error
Vikalpa	verbal construction without corresponding object
Nidra	sleep supported by cognition of absence
Smṛti	retention and recollection

Each may be klista or aklista. Even valid cognition is a vrtti because it modifies mind-field (citta) and can sustain identification, though aklista cognition helps generate discrimination.

Yoga prescribes nirodha because the seer mistakes reflected mental states for itself. Modification creates saṁskara; saṁskara generates further vrtti and karmic continuity. Through sustained practice (abhyāsa) and dispassion (vairāgya) this cycle is restrained:

vrtti -> identification -> affliction (kleśa) -> action and moral consequence (karma) -> saṁskara -> further vrtti
nirodha -> viveka -> non-identification -> isolation (kaivalya)

Nirodha is not destruction of mind or blankness. It is disciplined cessation allowing Conscious witness (puruṣa) to abide in its own nature.

Verdict: Cessation is prescribed not because cognition is intrinsically evil, but because unrestrained modification obscures the distinction between seer and seen.

Why this earns marks: It defines mind-field (citta), lists all vrttis, explains the saṁskara loop and gives a non-nihilistic account of nirodha.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Appraise Yoga soteriology in light of citta-reflection and self-identification.

Model solution

Yoga accepts the Samkhya dualism of inactive consciousness and active but unconscious mind-field (citta). Mind-field (citta) is sattva-predominant and transparent; it reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa) like a crystal reflecting a flower. It thereby appears conscious, while Conscious witness (puruṣa) appears to know, act and suffer.

Bondage begins when **ego-identification (asmitā)** identifies drk-sakti, the seer's power, with darsana-sakti, the seeing instrument. Vrttis become appropriated as "I think," "I desire" and "I suffer." Afflictions (kleśas) generate action and moral consequence (karma), deposits and rebirth.

Yoga's soteriology transforms the reflecting medium:

1. yama-niyama reduce moral disturbance;
2. asana-pranayama stabilize body and vitality;
3. sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra) withdraws sensory dispersion;
4. dharana-dhyana-samadhi produce one-pointed transparency;
5. discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) permanently distinguishes Conscious witness (puruṣa) from mind-field (citta).

Isolation (kaivalya) does not alter Conscious witness (puruṣa); it ends misattribution. The qualities (guṇas) cease functioning for that Conscious witness (puruṣa) and return toward their causal ground.

The objection is that reflection presupposes a relation between ontologically separate principles. Mere proximity names rather than explains it. Yoga replies that all change occurs on the mind-field (citta) side; Conscious witness (puruṣa) remains untouched.

Verdict: Yoga offers a coherent therapy of misidentification, though its reflection model inherits Samkhya's unresolved interaction problem.

Why this earns marks: It translates the quotation, traces the complete therapeutic sequence and gives the strongest metaphysical criticism.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of God and its role in Isolation (kaivalya) in Yoga.

Model solution

Lord (Īśvara) is a **special Conscious witness (puruṣa)** untouched by afflictions (kleśas), action and moral consequence (karma), karmic fruition and latent impressions. He is eternally free, omniscient in the unsurpassed sense and the timeless teacher of earlier teachers. Pranava is his verbal symbol.

Lord (Īśvara) is not Primordial material nature (prakṛti), not one liberated Conscious witness (puruṣa) among others, and not straightforwardly the creator-God of Nyaya. Patanjali's primary interest is practical. **Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna)** weakens egoism, creates one-pointed devotion, removes obstacles and offers a direct aid to meditative absorption (samādhi).

Isolation (kaivalya) nevertheless consists in discriminative knowledge between Conscious witness (puruṣa) and Primordial material nature (prakṛti). God does not absorb the individual, grant union with himself, or replace citta-nirodha. His role is privileged but instrumental:

Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna) -> reduced obstacles and ego
-> deeper meditative absorption (samādhi) -> discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)
-> cessation of guna-purpose -> isolation (kaivalya)

Critics ask why Lord (Īśvara) is needed if the Samkhya ontology and viveka already suffice. Yoga may concede that other routes exist while insisting that devotion is uniquely efficient and that timeless teacherhood grounds the transmission of liberating knowledge.

Verdict: Lord (Īśvara) distinguishes Yoga from nirisvara Samkhya, but isolation (kaivalya) remains isolation of Conscious witness (puruṣa) through discrimination, not salvation by divine fusion.

Why this earns marks: It defines Lord (Īśvara) precisely, states positive and negative functions, connects devotion to isolation (kaivalya) and evaluates the redundancy objection.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Why does Yoga count valid cognition among the vṛttis to be restrained?

Model solution

Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) presents objects truly, but it still modifies mind-field (citta) and can sustain identification: "I know." Yoga distinguishes epistemic truth from soteriological freedom. Valid cognition may be akliṣṭa and assist viveka, yet any object-form is still part of the seen.

The path therefore uses true cognition to remove error and finally relinquishes even the instrument when stable discrimination is achieved-like a thorn removing a thorn.

Verdict: Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) is not condemned as false; it is transcended because isolation (kaivalya) requires freedom from all citta-identification.

Why this earns marks: It resolves the apparent paradox and distinguishes truth-value from liberating finality.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Is Astanga Yoga an ethical psychology rather than a sequence of exercises?

Model solution

The eight limbs form a causal architecture. Ethical restraint (yama) and observance (niyama) reduce interpersonal and intrapsychic disturbance. Posture (āsana) stabilizes embodiment; breath regulation (prāṇāyāma) regulates vitality and attention; sense withdrawal (pratyāhāra) breaks sensory compulsion. Concentration (dhāraṇā), meditation (dhyāna) and meditative absorption (samādhi) progressively unify cognition.

The limbs therefore transform habits, affects, attention and identity. Without non-violence, truthfulness and non-grasping, concentration may strengthen ego and affliction (kleśa) rather than dissolve them. Without the inner limbs, ethics remains good conduct but does not mature into direct discrimination.

Verdict: Astanga is an ethical psychology completed in meditative epistemology; treating it as bodily exercise severs the very mechanism by which it leads to isolation (kaivalya).

Why this earns marks: It explains the functional relation among all limbs and states why ethical preparation is philosophically necessary.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Lord (Īśvara) is indispensable to Yoga practice but dispensable to Yoga metaphysics." Critically examine.

Model solution

Yoga's metaphysical framework largely follows Samkhya: Conscious witness (puruṣa), Primordial material nature (prakṛti), qualities (guṇas), mind-field (citta), action and moral consequence (karma) and viveka explain bondage and liberation. Isolation (kaivalya) occurs through discriminative knowledge, not union with or creation by God. This supports the claim of metaphysical dispensability.

Yet Lord (Īśvara) is more than ornament. As puruṣa-viśeṣa he represents eternally unobstructed consciousness, grounds timeless teacherhood, supplies pranava as meditative support and makes surrender a powerful antidote to egoism. Patanjali explicitly presents Dedication to the Lord (Īśvara-praṇidhāna) as a route to meditative absorption (samādhi).

The strongest instrumental reading says other means-sustained practice (abhyāsa), dispassion (vairāgya) and astanga-can also lead to realization, so Lord (Īśvara) is a uniquely efficient optional aid. A stronger theistic reading argues that transmission of liberating knowledge and coordination of Puruṣa-Prakṛti require him; later commentators expand this role.

The redundancy objection remains: if Lord (Īśvara) neither creates Primordial material nature (prakṛti) nor grants liberation, Yoga's distinct theism seems thin. The reply is that practical indispensability need not mean cosmological authorship. A perfect intentional object can reorganize mind-field (citta) without replacing its own effort and insight.

Verdict: The statement is broadly correct but too sharp. Lord (Īśvara) is not constitutive of the material ontology or formal definition of isolation (kaivalya), yet he is philosophically significant as exemplar, teacher and privileged technology of de-centering the ego.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes metaphysical, epistemic and practical roles, presents competing readings and reaches a qualified verdict.

How to improve this answer: Re-check the exact directive in *Model solution*, add one named canonical text or school-specific argument, state the strongest objection and reply, and end with a qualified verdict rather than a generic summary.

Exam-length execution: For 10/15/20 marks, compress this into roughly 150/250/250 words respectively: definition and thesis; two or three claim -> named evidence -> analysis units; one objection/reply; then a one-sentence qualified conclusion.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

OPTIONAL DEPTH 1 - Yoga as Theistic Samkhya (śeśvara-sāṃkhya) and the Structure of Mind-field (citta)

Advanced reflection problem

Mind-field (citta) unifies determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṃkāra) and sensory mind (manas) as one operative field. It is materially subtle and sattva-dominant, so it can reflect consciousness while remaining insentient in itself. Bondage occurs when borrowed luminosity is mistaken for intrinsic selfhood.

The reflection model protects an unchanging Conscious witness (puruṣa): every transformation occurs on the mind-field (citta) side. Yet it presupposes an intelligible relation between radically different orders. Mere proximity avoids physical interaction but does not completely explain how one experience contains both object-form and witnesshood.

The citta-bhumi scheme is soteriological rather than a generic intelligence scale. A scientist may display powerful but outward and intermittent focus, while only one-pointed mind (ekāgra) and fully restrained mind (niruddha) are fully suited to liberating Yoga.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 2 - Restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha): Five Modifications and Real Transformation of Mind

Advanced transformation and continuity

Vṛttis may be afflicted or non-afflicted. Yoga therefore proceeds therapeutically: aklista cognition and disciplined memory replace afflicted patterns before all object-identification subsides. Nirodha is revelatory restraint, not violent destruction or unconscious blankness.

Citta-parinama supplies a realist account of progress. Nirodha-parinama strengthens impressions of restraint; samadhi-parinama shifts from many-pointedness to absorption; ekagrata-parinama stabilizes one-pointed continuity. These changes presuppose a persisting prakritic substrate rather than momentary flashes.

Buddhist momentariness can explain habits through causal series, but Yoga argues that a continuing mind-field (citta) better bears samskaras and graded transformation. The dispute concerns whether continuity requires a substrate or only a stream.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 3 - Afflictions (kleśas), Action and moral consequence (karma) and Astanga Yoga: The Causal Therapy of Bondage

Advanced moral psychology

Ignorance (avidyā) is not missing information but systematic inversion: impermanent as permanent, impure as pure, painful as pleasant and non-self as self. The other afflictions (kleśas) can be dormant, thinned, interrupted or active; temporary suppression is not destruction.

Karmasaya and vipaka turn psychology into a theory of cycle of rebirth (saṃsāra). Afflicted action leaves deposits that ripen as birth, lifespan and experience. The burnt-seed model explains why meditation can remove future fertility even while already-fructifying embodiment retains momentum.

Astanga is an ethical psychology rather than an exercise sequence. Without ethical restraint (yama) and observance (niyama), concentration can magnify ego and affliction. Without the inner limbs, ethical conduct remains incomplete as a route to direct discrimination.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 4 - Meditative absorption (samādhi): Object-Supported Insight, Seedless Restraint and Classification Control

Advanced interpretive control

Samprajnata retains cognition and support. Its canonical factors are vitarka, vicara, ananda and ego-identification (asmitā). The separate samapatti analysis distinguishes gross and subtle object-absorption according to whether conceptual-verbal overlay remains. Conflating these schemes is a major doctrinal error.

Mature nirvicara yields truth-bearing insight, but even exalted cognition remains an event in mind-field (citta). Asamprajnata arises through disciplined restraint and may retain residual samskara; nirbija marks the further cessation of that seed. Therefore neither state should be equated casually with sleep or blankness.

Siddhis can accompany integrated concentration (saṃyama) but become obstacles when appropriated.

Dharmamegha meditative absorption (samādhi) and supreme dispassion turn the path away from powers toward final discrimination.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 5 - Isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara): Isolation, Discernment and the Special Conscious witness (puruṣa)

Advanced necessity and redundancy

Isolation (kaivalya) is needed at the empirical level even though Conscious witness (puruṣa) is eternally pure because misidentification operates through mind-field (citta). Discipline removes obstructions like a farmer opening a channel; it does not manufacture freedom. Burnt seed and potter's wheel images explain the end of future bondage and residual embodiment.

Lord (Īśvara) is metaphysically limited but practically significant. He neither becomes the world nor grants liberation by fiat. As timeless teacher, perfect exemplar and pranava-supported meditative object, he de-centres ego and removes obstacles.

The redundancy objection therefore has force: Samkhya ontology and viveka can formally explain liberation without God. Yoga's strongest reply is soteriological rather than cosmological-practical indispensability for some aspirants need not imply creatorhood.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 6 - Inter-School Debates, Realism, Criticisms and UPSC Traps

Advanced realist and interaction debates

Against Yogacara, Yoga defends three-term realism: external object, citta-modification and witnessing Conscious witness (puruṣa). Objects are not dependent on one mind, and mind-field (citta) cannot be self-luminous because it is itself seen. Shared karmic appearance remains a sophisticated idealist counter.

The recurring internal objection concerns dualist interaction. Reflection and proximity explain why Conscious witness (puruṣa) does not change, but critics may still ask how ontologically distinct principles jointly constitute experience.

Yoga is strongest as operational moral psychology: it connects habit, attention, memory, latent impression, affliction and meditative transformation. Its metaphysical claims about Conscious witness (puruṣa), rebirth and yogic perception face a greater public verification burden.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 7 - Advanced Ledgers, Comparative Positioning and the Graded Verdict

Advanced system assessment

Yoga's architecture is unusually integrated. Mind-field (citta) and vṛtti give phenomenology; affliction (kleśa) and action and moral consequence (karma) give moral causation; astanga supplies method; meditative absorption (samādhi) gives meditative epistemology; viveka and isolation (kaivalya) complete liberation.

Its costs are inherited and added. The system must defend plural inactive witnesses, a continuing subtle mind, karmic deposits, extraordinary cognition and a special Conscious witness (puruṣa) whose practical role exceeds his cosmological role.

Controlled Western comparisons may clarify suspension, witness-consciousness or habit, but must remain secondary. Husserlian reduction does not seek isolation (kaivalya), Cartesian consciousness acts, and psychoanalytic dispositions lack Yoga's rebirth framework.

OPTIONAL DEPTH 8 - PYQ Routing, Current Linkage and Complete Exam Deployment

Advanced current linkage and corpus strategy

The 2026 International Day of Yoga theme, **Yoga for Healthy Ageing**, and Ministry of Ayush public programmes provide a verified contemporary opening for preventive health and broad participation. They do not prove Patanjali's metaphysics or replace restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha), klesa-removal, meditative absorption (samādhi) and isolation (kaivalya).

This doctrine boundary is exam-useful: public Yoga shows contemporary social relevance, while philosophical Yoga asks a different question-how disciplined transformation of mind-field (citta) ends misidentification and karmic bondage.

The corpus is modular. Master citta-bhumis, five vṛttis, five afflictions (kleśas), eight limbs, meditative absorption (samādhi) distinctions, isolation (kaivalya) and Lord (Īśvara); then route each question to the correct block.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - YOGA

System Spine

MENTAL MODIFICATION (citta-vṛtti) + AFFLICTION (kleśa)
-> ACTION AND MORAL CONSEQUENCE (karma) + SAMSKARA + REBIRTH
-> SUSTAINED PRACTICE (abhyāsa) + DISPASSION (vairāgya) + KRIYA/ASTANGA
-> MEDITATIVE ABSORPTION (samādhi) + DISCRIMINATIVE INSIGHT (viveka-khyāti)
-> REVERSE EVOLUTION (pratiprasava)
-> ISOLATION (kaivalya)

Mind-field (citta)

- Material-subtle inner instrument: determinative intellect (buddhi), ego-maker (ahaṁkāra), sensory mind (manas).
- Reflects Conscious witness (puruṣa) and assumes object-forms.
- Five bhumis: restless mind (kṣipta), dull mind (mūḍha), distracted mind (vikṣipta), one-pointed mind (ekāgra), fully restrained mind (niruddha).
- One-pointed mind (ekāgra) and fully restrained mind (niruddha) are Yoga-fit.

Five Vrttis

- Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa): valid cognition.
- Viparyaya: error.
- Vikalpa: word-construction without object.
- Nidra: sleep based on absence-cognition.
- Smṛti: recollection.
- Each can be klista or aklista.
- Nirodha is restraint, not unconscious destruction.

Five Afflictions (kleśas)

- Ignorance (avidyā): root misapprehension.
- Ego-identification (asmitā): seer-seen identification.
- Attachment (rāga): attachment.
- Aversion (dveṣa): aversion.
- Clinging to life (abhiniveśa): clinging to life.
- States: prasupta, tanu, vicchinna, udara.

Eight Limbs

ETHICAL RESTRAINT (yama) -> OBSERVANCE (niyama) -> POSTURE (āsana) -> BREATH REGULATION (prāṇāyāma)
-> SENSE WITHDRAWAL (pratyāhāra) -> CONCENTRATION (dhāraṇā) -> MEDITATION (dhyāna) -> MEDITATIVE
ABSORPTION (samādhi)

- Ethical restraint (yama): ahimsa, satya, asteya, brahmacharya, aparigraha.
- Observance (niyama): saucha, santosa, tapas, svadhyaya, Dedication to the Lord (īśvara-praṇidhāna).
- Final three combine as integrated concentration (saṁyama).

Meditative absorption (samādhi)

- Samprajñata: object-supported cognitive absorption.
- Fourfold character: vitarka, vicara, ananda, ego-identification (asmitā).
- Samapattis: savitarka/nirvitarka; savicara/nirvicara.
- Rāmbhara prajña: truth-bearing insight.
- Asamprajñata: beyond cognitive objectification, residual seed may remain.
- Nirbija: even seed ceases.
- Dharmamegha: supreme dispassion and final transition.

Lord (Īśvara)

- Purusa-visesa untouched by affliction (kleśa), action and moral consequence (karma), vipaka and asaya.
- Omniscient and timeless teacher.
- Pranava is symbol.
- Removes obstacles and accelerates meditative absorption (samādhi).
- Not straightforward Nyaya creator or Vedantic absolute.
- Does not replace discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti).

Isolation (kaivalya)

- Isolation/self-establishment of Conscious witness (puruṣa).
- Mind-field (citta) completes its purpose; qualities (guṇas) undergo reverse evolution (pratiprasava).
- Conscious witness (puruṣa) was never intrinsically modified.
- Not union with Brahman or God.
- Not blank unconsciousness.

PYQ Route Map

- 2019: scientist, devotee and yogi citta-levels.
- 2020: samprajnata versus asamprajnata.
- 2021: afflictions (kleśas) and isolation (kaivalya).
- 2022: meditative absorption (samādhi) stages and Lord (Īśvara).
- 2023: mind-field (citta), vṛttis and nirodha.
- 2024: reflection and Yoga soteriology.
- 2025: God and isolation (kaivalya).

Final Traps

1. Yoga is not merely posture (āśana).
2. Mind-field (citta) is not Conscious witness (puruṣa).
3. One-pointed mind (ekāgra) is not identical with fully restrained mind (niruddha).
4. Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa) can be true yet remain a vṛtti.
5. Nidra is a vṛtti; asamprajnata is not sleep.
6. Samprajnata's fourfold list is not identical to samapatti subtypes.
7. Lord (Īśvara) is purusa-visesa, not material cause.
8. Meditative absorption (samādhi) supports liberation; discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti) is decisive.
9. Isolation (kaivalya) is isolation, not divine union.
10. Public-health Yoga is contemporary linkage, not a substitute for Patanjala doctrine.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/8: Mind-field architecture

YOGA: DISCIPLINE OF THE MIND-FIELD (CITTA)

objects -> senses -> mind-field (citta) -> conscious witness (puruṣa)
determinate intellect (buddhi) + ego-maker (ahaṁkāra) + sensory mind (manas)
bondage = the witness mistakes reflected mental states for itself
core aim -> restraint of mental modifications (citta-vṛtti-nirodha)

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/8: Mental modifications and restraint

FIVE MENTAL MODIFICATIONS (CITTA-VṚTTIS)

perception/inference/testimony | error | construction | sleep | memory
each may be afflicted or unafflicted; even valid cognition is a modification
sustained practice (abhyāsa) + dispassion (vairāgya) -> progressive restraint
trap: restraint is disciplined lucidity, not unconscious blankness

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/8: Afflictions and karmic chain

ignorance (avidyā) -> ego-identification (asmitā)
-> attachment (rāga) / aversion (dveṣa) -> clinging to life (abhiniveśa)
afflictions (kleśas) -> action -> latent deposit -> fruition -> rebirth
preparatory discipline (kriyā-yoga) thins afflictions
meditation burns the remaining seeds and makes discriminative insight possible

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/8: Eight-limbed discipline

EIGHT-LIMBED DISCIPLINE (AṢṬĀṅGA-YOGA)

ethical restraint -> observance -> posture -> breath regulation
-> sense withdrawal -> concentration -> meditation -> absorption
first five prepare body, conduct and attention; final three form integrated concentration
trap: posture is one limb, not the definition or final goal of Yoga

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/8: Absorption ladder

OBJECT-SUPPORTED ABSORPTION (SAMPRAJÑĀTA-SAMĀDHI)

gross reasoning -> subtle reflection -> joy -> I-am-ness
truth-bearing insight -> objectless absorption -> seedless absorption
cloud-of-virtue absorption (dharmamegha-samādhī) ends affliction and action
do not conflate the four YS 1.17 supports with the separate absorption taxonomy

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/8: Lord and discriminative insight

LORD (ĪŚVARA) = SPECIAL CONSCIOUS WITNESS, UNTOUCHED BY AFFLICTION OR ACTION
dedication to the Lord -> concentration aid + timeless teacher
not the material creator of Nyaya and not a substitute for practice
decisive knowledge = discriminative insight (viveka-khyāti)
Yoga is theistic Samkhya in method, while liberation remains discriminative

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/8: Isolation and the relation problem

ISOLATION (KAIVALYA) = THE WITNESS ESTABLISHED IN ITS OWN NATURE

reverse evolution returns constituent qualities to primordial material nature
objection: how can inactive consciousness relate to insentient mind?
reply: reflection and mere proximity protect the witness from change
residual limit: proximity names the relation more clearly than it explains it

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/8: PYQ answer synthesis

DEFINE -> CLASSIFY -> EXPLAIN MECHANISM -> CONNECT PRACTICE -> EVALUATE
mind-field -> modifications -> afflictions -> eight limbs -> absorption -> isolation
use the exact question's doctrine; distinguish Lord, witness and mind
add one named objection and the strongest Yoga reply
qualified verdict: rigorous psychology and praxis, contested dualist relation